Eurípides · *Medea*

Texto en griego y traducción inglesa alineados por pasaje; cada sección de la traducción figura una sola vez, junto al primer pasaje que abarca.

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Disposición: el texto griego de cada grupo de pasajes va seguido de la sección correspondiente de la traducción inglesa.

1.1

1 Εἴθ’ ὤφελ’ Ἀργοῦς μὴ διαπτάσθαι σκάφος
2 Κόλχων ἐς αἶαν κυανέας Συμπληγάδας,
3 μηδ’ ἐν νάπαισι Πηλίου πεσεῖν ποτε
4 τμηθεῖσα πεύκη, μηδ’ ἐρετμῶσαι χέρας
5 ἀνδρῶν ἀρίστων, οἳ τὸ πάγχρυσον δέρας
6 Πελίᾳ μετῆλθον. οὐ γὰρ ἂν δέσποιν’ ἐμὴ
7 Μήδεια πύργους γῆς ἔπλευσ’ Ἰωλκίας
8 ἔρωτι θυμὸν ἐκπλαγεῖσ’ Ἰάσονος·
9 οὐδ’ ἂν κτανεῖν πείσασα Πελιάδας κόρας
10 πατέρα κατῴκει τήνδε γῆν Κορινθίαν
11 ξὺν ἀνδρὶ καὶ τέκνοισιν, ἀνδάνουσα μὲν
12 φυγῇ πολιτῶν ὧν ἀφίκετο χθόνα,
13 αὐτή τε πάντα ξυμφέρουσ’ Ἰάσονι·
14 ἥπερ μεγίστη γίγνεται σωτηρία,
15 ὅταν γυνὴ πρὸς ἄνδρα μὴ διχοστατῇ.
16 νῦν δ’ ἐχθρὰ πάντα, καὶ νοσεῖ τὰ φίλτατα.
17 προδοὺς γὰρ αὐτοῦ τέκνα δεσπότιν τ’ ἐμὴν
18 γάμοις Ἰάσων βασιλικοῖς εὐνάζεται,
19 γήμας Κρέοντος παῖδ’, ὃς αἰσύμνᾷ χθονός·
20 Μήδεια δ’ ἡ δύστηνος ἠτιμασμένη
21 βοᾷ μὲν ὅρκους, ἀνακαλεῖ δὲ δεξιάς,
22 πίστιν μεγίστην, καὶ θεοὺς μαρτύρεται
23 οἵας ἀμοιβῆς ἐξ Ἰάσονος κυρεῖ.
24 κεῖται δ’ ἄσιτος, σῶμ’ ὑφεῖσ’ ἀλγηδόσι,
25 τὸν πάντα συντήκουσα δακρύοις χρόνον,
26 ἐπεὶ πρὸς ἀνδρὸς ᾔσθετ’ ἠδικημένη,
27 οὔτ’ ὄμμ’ ἐπαίρουσ’ οὔτ’ ἀπαλλάσσουσα γῆς
28 πρόσωπον· ὡς δὲ πέτρος ἢ θαλάσσιος
29 κλύδων ἀκούει νουθετουμένη φίλων·
30 ἢν μή ποτε στρέψασα πάλλευκον δέρην
96 (within). Ah, me! a wretched suffering woman I! O would that I could die!

1.31

31 αὐτὴ πρὸς αὑτὴν πατέρ’ ἀποιμώξῃ φίλον
32 καὶ γαῖαν οἴκους θ’, οὓς προδοῦσ’ ἀφίκετο
33 μετ’ ἀνδρὸς ὅς σφε νῦν ἀτιμάσας ἔχει.
34 ἔγνωκε δ’ ἡ τάλαινα συμφορᾶς ὕπο

οἷον πατρῴας μὴ ἀπολείπεσθαι χθονός.
στυγεῖ δὲ παῖδας οὐδ’ ὁρῶσ’ εὐφραίνεται.
δέδοικα δ’ αὐτὴν μή τι βουλεύσῃ νέον·
βαρεῖα γὰρ φρήν, οὐδ’ ἀνέξεται κακῶς
πάσχουσ’· ἐγῷδα τήνδε, δειμαίνω τέ νιν
μὴ θηκτὸν ὥσῃ φάσγανον δι’ ἥπατος,
σιγῇ δόμους εἰσβᾶσ’, ἵν’ ἔστρωται λέχος,
ἢ καὶ τύραννον τόν τε γήμαντα κτάνῃ,
κἄπειτα μείζω συμφορὰν λάβῃ τινά.
δεινὴ γάρ· οὔτοι ῥᾳδίως γε συμβαλὼν
ἔχθραν τις αὐτῇ καλλίνικον οἴσεται.
ἀλλ’ οἵδε παῖδες ἐκ τρόχων πεπαυμένοι
στείχουσι, μητρὸς οὐδὲν ἐννοούμενοι
κακῶν· νέα γὰρ φροντὶς οὐκ ἀλγεῖν φιλεῖ.
παλαιὸν οἴκων κτῆμα δεσποίνης ἐμῆς,
τί πρὸς πύλαισι τήνδ’ ἄγουσ’ ἐρημίαν
ἕστηκας, αὐτὴ θρεομένη σαυτῇ κακά;
πῶς σοῦ μόνη Μήδεια λείπεσθαι θέλει;
τέκνων ὀπαδὲ πρέσβυ τῶν Ἰάσονος,
χρηστοῖσι δούλοις ξυμφορὰ τὰ δεσποτῶν
κακῶς πίτνοντα, καὶ φρενῶν ἀνθάπτεται.
ἐγὼ γὰρ ἐς τοῦτ’ ἐκβέβηκ’ ἀλγηδόνος,
ὥσθ’ ἵμερός μ’ ὑπῆλθε γῇ τε κοὐρανῷ
λέξαι μολούσῃ δεῦρο δεσποίνης τύχας.
οὔπω γὰρ ἡ τάλαινα παύεται γόων;
ζηλῶ σ’· ἐν ἀρχῇ πῆμα κοὐδέπω μεσοῖ.

1 Ah! would to Heaven the good ship Argo ne’er had sped its course to the Colchian land through the misty blue Symplegades, nor ever in the glens of Pelion the pine been felled to furnish with oars the chieftain’s hands, 5 who went to fetch the golden fleece for Pelias; for then would my own mistress Medea never have sailed to the turrets of Iolcos, her soul with love for Jason smitten, nor would she have beguiled the daughters of Pelias 10 to slay their father and come to live here in the land of Corinth with her husband and children, where her exile found favour with the citizens to whose land she had come, and in all things of her own accord was she at one with Jason, the greatest safeguard this 15 when wife and husband do agree; but now their love is all turned to hate, and tenderest ties are weak. For Jason hath betrayed his own children and my mistress dear for the love of a royal bride, for he hath wedded the daughter of Creon, lord of this land. 20 While Medea his hapless wife, thus scorned, appeals to the oaths he swore, recalls the strong pledge his right hand gave, and bids heaven be witness what requital she is finding from Jason. And here she lies fasting, yielding her body to her grief, 25 wasting away in tears ever since she learnt that she was wronged by her husband, never lifting her eye nor raising her face from off the ground; and she lends as deaf an ear to her friend’s warning as if she were a rock or ocean billow, save when she turns her snow-white neck aside 30 and softly to herself bemoans her father dear, her country and her home, which she gave up to come hither with the man who now holds her in dishonour. She, poor lady, hath by sad experience learnt how good a thing it is 35 never to quit one’s native land. And she hates her children now and feels no joy at seeing them; I am afeard she may contrive some untoward scheme; for her mood is dangerous nor will she brook her cruel treatment; full well I know her, and I much do dread 40 that she will plunge the keen sword through their heart, stealing without a word into the chamber where their marriage couch is spread, or else that she will slay the prince and bridegroom too, and so find some calamity still more grievous than the present; for dreadful

is her wrath; 45 verily the man that doth incur her hate will have no easy task to raise o’er her a song of triumph. Lo! where her sons come hither from their childish sports; little they reck of their mother’s woes, for the soul of the young is no inend to sorrow. 49 Why dost thou, so long my lady’s own handmaid, 50 stand here at the gate alone, loudly lamenting to thyself the piteous tale? how comes it that Medea will have thee leave her to herself? 53 Old man, attendant on the sons of Jason, our masters’ fortunes when they go awry make good slaves grieve 55 and touch their hearts. Oh! I have come to such a pitch of grief that there stole a yearning wish upon me to come forth hither and proclaim to heaven and earth my mistress’s hard fate. 59 What! has not the poor lady ceased yet from her lamentation? 60 Would I were as thou art! the mischief is but now beginning; it has not reached its climax yet. 61 O foolish one, if I may call my mistress such a name; how little she recks of evils yet more recent! 63 What mean’st, old man? grudge not to tell me. 64 ’Tis naught; I do repent me even of the words I have spoken. 65 Nay, by thy beard I conjure thee, hide it not from thy fellow-slave; I will be silent, if need be, on that text. 67 I heard one say, pretending not to listen as I approached the place where our greybeards sit playing draughts near Pirene’s sacred spring, 70 that Creon, the ruler of this land, is bent on driving these children and their mother from the boundaries of Corinth; but I know not whether the news is to be relied upon, and would fain it were not. 74 What! will Jason brook such treatment of his sons, 75 even though he be at variance with their mother? 76 Old ties give way to new; he bears no longer any love to this family. 78 Undone, it seems, are we, if to old woes fresh ones we add, ere we have drained the former to the dregs. 80 Hold thou thy peace, say not a word of this; ’tis no time for our mistress to learn hereof. 82 O children, do ye hear how your father feels towards you? Perdition catch him, but no! he is my master still; yet is he proved a veiy traitor to his nearest and dearest. 85 And who ’mongst men is not? Art learning only now, that every single man cares for himself more than for his neighbour, some from honest, motives, others for mere gain’s sake? seeing that to indulge his passion their father has ceased to love these children. 89 Go, children, within the house; all will be well. 90 Do thou keep them as far away as may be, and bring them not near their mother in her evil hour. For ere this have I seen her eyeing them savagely, as though she were minded to do them some hurt, and well I know she will not cease from her fury till she have pounced on some victim. 95 At least may she turn her hand against her foes, and not against her friends.

1.61

61 ὦ μῶρος—εἰ χρὴ δεσπότας εἰπεῖν τόδε·
62 ὡς οὐδὲν οἶδε τῶν νεωτέρων κακῶν.
63 τί δ’ ἔστιν, ὦ γεραιέ; μὴ φθόνει φράσαι.
64 οὐδέν· μετέγνων καὶ τὰ πρόσθ’ εἰρημένα.
65 μή, πρὸς γενείου, κρύπτε σύνδουλον σέθεν·
66 σιγὴν γάρ, εἰ χρή, τῶνδε θήσομαι πέρι.
67 ἤκουσά του λέγοντος, οὐ δοκῶν κλύειν,
68 πεσσοὺς προσελθών, ἔνθα δὴ παλαίτατοι
69 θάσσουσι, σεμνὸν ἀμφὶ Πειρήνης ὕδωρ,
70 ὡς τούσδε παῖδας γῆς ἐλᾶν Κορινθίας
71 σὺν μητρὶ μέλλοι τῆσδε κοίρανος χθονὸς
72 Κρέων. ὁ μέντοι μῦθος εἰ σαφὴς ὅδε
73 οὐκ οἶδα· βουλοίμην δ’ ἂν οὐκ εἶναι τόδε.
74 καὶ ταῦτ’ Ἰάσων παῖδας ἐξανέξεται
75 πάσχοντας, εἰ καὶ μητρὶ διαφορὰν ἔχει;
76 παλαιὰ καινῶν λείπεται κηδευμάτων,
77 κοὐκ ἔστ’ ἐκεῖνος τοῖσδε δώμασιν φίλος.

78 ἀπωλόμεσθ’ ἄρ’, εἰ κακὸν προσοίσομεν
79 νέον παλαιῷ, πρὶν τόδ’ ἐξηντληκέναι.
80 ἀτὰρ σύ γ’—οὐ γὰρ καιρὸς εἰδέναι τόδε
81 δέσποιναν—ἡσύχαζε καὶ σίγα λόγον.
82 ὦ τέκν’, ἀκούεθ’ οἷος εἰς ὑμᾶς πατήρ;
83 ὅλοιτο μὲν μή· δεσπότης γάρ ἐστ’ ἐμός·
84 ἀτὰρ κακός γ’ ὢν ἐς φίλους ἀλίσκεται.
85 τίς δ’ οὐχὶ θνητῶν; ἄρτι γιγνώσκεις τόδε,
86 ὡς πᾶς τις αὐτὸν τοῦ πέλας μᾶλλον φιλεῖ,
87 οἳ μὲν δικαίως, οἳ δὲ καὶ κέρδους χάριν,
88 εἰ τούσδε γ’ εὐνῆς οὕνεκ’ οὐ στέργει πατήρ.
89 ἴτ’—εὖ γὰρ ἔσται—δωμάτων ἔσω, τέκνα.
90 σὺ δ’ ὡς μάλιστα τούσδ’ ἐρημώσας ἔχε

1.91

91 καὶ μὴ πέλαζε μητρὶ δυσθυμουμένῃ.
92 ἤδη γὰρ εἶδον ὄμμα νιν ταυρουμένην
93 τοῖσδ’, ὥς τι δρασείουσαν· οὐδὲ παύσεται
94 χόλου, σάφ’ οἶδα, πρὶν κατασκῆψαί τινα . . .
95 ἐχθρούς γε μέντοι, μὴ φίλους, δράσειέ τι.

1.1

96 ἰώ,
96a δύστανος ἐγὼ μελέα τε πόνων,
97 ἰώ μοί μοι, πῶς ἂν ὀλοίμαν;

1.2

98 τόδ’ ἐκεῖνο, φίλοι παῖδες· μήτηρ
99 κινεῖ κραδίαν, κινεῖ δὲ χόλον.
100 σπεύσατε θᾶσσον δώματος εἴσω
101 καὶ μὴ πελάσητ’ ὄμματος ἐγγύς,
102 μηδὲ προσέλθητ’, ἀλλὰ φυλάσσεσθ’
103 ἄγριον ἦθος στυγεράν τε φύσιν
104 φρενὸς αὐθάδους.—
105 ἴτε νῦν, χωρεῖθ’ ὡς τάχος εἴσω.—
106 δῆλον δ’ ἀρχῆς ἐξαιρόμενον
107 νέφος οἰμωγῆς ὡς τάχ’ ἀνάψει
108 μείζονι θυμῷ· τί ποτ’ ἐργάσεται
109 μεγαλόσπλαγχνος δυσκατάπαυστος
110 ψυχὴ δηχθεῖσα κακοῖσιν;
98 ’Tis as I said, my dear children; wild fancies stir your mother’s heart, wild fury goads her on. 100 Into the house without delay, come not near her eye, approach her not, beware her savage mood, the fell tempest of her reckless heart. 105 In, in with what speed ye may. For ’tis plain she will soon redouble her fury; that cry is but the herald of the gathering storm-cloud whose lightning soon will flash; what will her proud restless 110 soul, in the anguish of despair, be guilty of? [Exit Attendant with the children.

1.3

111 αἰαῖ,

111a ἔπαθον τλάμων ἔπαθον μεγάλων
112 ἄξι’ ὀδυρμῶν· ὦ κατάρατοι
113 παῖδες ὄλοισθε στυγερᾶς ματρὸς
114 σὺν πατρί, καὶ πᾶς δόμος ἔρροι.
111 (within). Ah, me! the agony I have suffered, deep enough to call for these laments! Curse you and your father too, ye children damned, sons of a doomed mother! Ruin seize the whole family!

1.4

115 ἰώ μοί μοι, ἰὼ τλήμων.
116 τί δέ σοι παῖδες πατρὸς ἀμπλακίας
117 μετέχουσι; τί τούσδ’ ἔχθεις; οἴμοι,
118 τέκνα, μή τι πάθηθ’ ὡς ὑπεραλγῶ.
119 δεινὰ τυράννων λήματα καί πως
120 ὀλίγ’ ἀρχόμενοι, πολλὰ κρατοῦντες
121 χαλεπῶς ὀργὰς μεταβάλλουσιν.
122 τὸ γὰρ εἰθίσθαι ζῆν ἐπ’ ἴσοισιν
123 κρεῖσσον· ἐμοὶ γοῦν ἐν μὴ μεγάλοις
124 ὀχυρῶς γ’ εἴη καταγηράσκειν.
125 τῶν γὰρ μετρίων πρῶτα μὲν εἰπεῖν
126 τοὔνομα νικᾷ, χρῆσθαί τε μακρῷ
127 λῷστα βροτοῖσιν· τὰ δ’ ὑπερβάλλοντ’
128 οὐδένα καιρὸν δύναται θνητοῖς·
129 μείζους δ’ ἄτας, ὅταν ὀργισθῇ
130 δαίμων οἴκοις, ἀπέδωκεν.
115 Ah me! ah me! the pity of it! Why, pray, do thy children share their father’s crime? Why hatest thou them? Woe is you, poor children, how do I grieve for you lest ye suffer some outrage! Strange are the tempers of princes, 120 and maybe because they seldom have to obey, and mostly lord it over others, change they their moods with difficulty. ’Tis better then to have been trained to live on equal terms. Be it mine to reach old age, not in proud pomp, but in security! 125 Moderation wins the day first as a better word for men to use, and likewise it is far the best course for them to pursue; but greatness that doth o’erreach itself, brings no blessing to mortal men; but pays a penalty of greater ruin whenever 130 fortune is wroth with a family.

1.5

131 ἔκλυον φωνάν, ἔκλυον δὲ βοὰν
132 τᾶς δυστάνου Κολχίδος, οὐδέ πω
133 ἥπιος· ἀλλ’ ὦ γηραιά,
134 λέξον· ἐπ’ ἀμφιπύλου γὰρ ἔσω μελάθρου βοὰν
135 ἔκλυον· οὐδὲ συνήδομαι, ὦ γύναι, ἄλγεσιν
136 δώματος· ἐπεί μοι φίλον κέκρανται.
131 I heard the voice, uplifted loud, of our poor Colchian lady, nor yet is she quiet; speak, aged dame, 135 for as I stood by the house with double gates I heard a voice of weeping from within, and I do grieve, lady, for the sorrows of this house, for it hath won my love.

1.6

139 οὐκ εἰσὶ δόμοι· φροῦδα τάδ’ ἤδη.
140 τὸν μὲν γὰρ ἔχει λέκτρα τυράννων,
141 ἃ δ’ ἐν θαλάμοις τάκει βιοτὰν

142 δέσποινα, φίλων οὐδενὸς οὐδὲν
143 παραθαλπομένα φρένα μύθοις.
144 αἰαῖ· ὦ Ζεῦ καὶ Γᾶ καὶ Φῶς·
144a διά μου κεφαλᾶς φλὸξ οὐρανία
145 βαίη· τί δέ μοι ζῆν ἔτι κέρδος;
146 φεῦ φεῦ· θανάτῳ καταλυσαίμαν
147 βιοτὰν στυγερὰν προλιποῦσα.
139 'Tis a house no more; all that is passed away long since; 140 a royal bride keeps Jason at her side, while our mistress pines away in her bower, finding no comfort for her soul in aught her friends can say. 144 (within). Oh, oh! Would that Heaven's levin bolt would cleave this head in twain! 145 What gain is life to me? Woe, woe is me! O, to die and win release, quitting this loathed existence!

1.1

148 —ἄιες· ὦ Ζεῦ καὶ γᾶ καὶ φῶς·
149 ἀχὰν οἵαν ἀ δύστανος
150 μέλπει νύμφα;
151 —τίς σοί ποτε τᾶς ἁπλάτου
152 κοίτας ἔρος, ὦ ματαία;
153 σπεύσει θανάτου τελευτά·
154 μηδὲν τόδε λίσσου.
155 —εἰ δὲ σὸς πόσις
156 καινὰ λέχη σεβίζει,
157 κείνῳ τόδε· μὴ χαράσσου·
158 —Ζεύς σοι τάδε συνδικήσει. μὴ λίαν
159 τάκου δυρομένα σὸν εὐνάταν.

1.8

160 ὦ μεγάλα Θέμι καὶ πότνι' Ἄρτεμι
161 λεύσσεθ' ἃ πάσχω, μεγάλοις ὅρκοις
162 ἐνδησαμένα τὸν κατάρατον
163 πόσιν; ὅν ποτ' ἐγὼ νύμφαν τ' ἐσίδοιμ'
164 αὐτοῖς μελάθροις διακναιομένους,
165 οἷ' ἐμὲ πρόσθεν τολμῶσ' ἀδικεῖν.
166 ὦ πάτερ, ὦ πόλις, ὧν ἀπενάσθην
167 αἰσχρῶς τὸν ἐμὸν κτείνασα κάσιν.
168 κλύεθ' οἷα λέγει κἀπιβοᾶται
169 Θέμιν εὐκταίαν Ζῆνά θ', ὃς ὅρκων
170 θνητοῖς ταμίας νενόμισται;
171 οὐκ ἔστιν ὅπως ἔν τινι μικρῷ
172 δέσποινα χόλον καταπαύσει.
160 (within). Great Themis, and husband of Themis, behold what I am suffering now, though I did bind that accursed one, my husband, by strong oaths to me? O, to see him and his bride some day brought to utter destruction, they and their house with them, 165 for that they presume to wrong me thus unprovoked. O my father, my country, that I have left to my shame, after slaying my own brother. 168 Do ye hear her words, how loudly she adjures Themis, oft invoked, and Zeus, whom 170 men regard as keeper of their oaths? On no mere trifle surely will our mistress spend her rage.

1.1

173 —πῶς ἂν ἐς ὄψιν τὰν ἀμετέραν
174 ἔλθοι μύθων τ’ αὐδαθέντων
175 δέξαιτ’ ὀμφάν;
176 —εἴ πως βαρύθυμον ὀργὰν
177 καὶ λῆμα φρενῶν μεθείη,
178 μήτοι τό γ’ ἐμὸν πρόθυμον
179 φίλοισιν ἀπέστω.
180 —ἀλλὰ βᾶσά νιν
181 δεῦρο πόρευσον οἴκων
182 ἔξω· φίλα καὶ τάδ’ αὔδα.
183 —σπεῦσον πρίν τι κακῶσαι τοὺς εἴσω·
183a πένθος γὰρ μεγάλως τόδ’ ὁρμᾶται.

1.10

184 δράσω τάδ’· ἀτὰρ φόβος εἰ πείσω
185 δέσποιναν ἐμήν·
186 μόχθου δὲ χάριν τήνδ’ ἐπιδώσω.
187 καίτοι τοκάδος δέργμα λεαίνης
188 ἀποταυροῦται δμωσίν, ὅταν τις
189 μῦθον προφέρων πέλας ὁρμηθῇ.
190 σκαιοὺς δὲ λέγων κοὐδέν τι σοφοὺς
191 τοὺς πρόσθε βροτοὺς οὐκ ἂν ἁμάρτοις,
192 οἵτινες ὕμνους ἐπὶ μὲν θαλίαις
193 ἐπί τ’ εἰλαπίναις καὶ παρὰ δείπνοις
194 ηὕροντο βίου τερπνὰς ἀκοάς·
195 στυγίους δὲ βροτῶν οὐδεὶς λύπας
196 ηὕρετο μούσῃ καὶ πολυχόρδοις
197 ᾠδαῖς παύειν, ἐξ ὧν θάνατοι
198 δειναί τε τύχαι σφάλλουσι δόμους.
199 καίτοι τάδε μὲν κέρδος ἀκεῖσθαι
200 μολπαῖσι βροτούς· ἵνα δ’ εὔδειπνοι
201 δαῖτες, τί μάτην τείνουσι βοήν;
202 τὸ παρὸν γὰρ ἔχει τέρψιν ἀφ’ αὑτοῦ
203 δαιτὸς πλήρωμα βροτοῖσιν.
184 This will I do; but I have my doubts whether I shall persuade 185 my mistress; still willingly will I undertake this trouble for you; albeit, she glares upon her servants with the look of a lioness with cubs, whenso anyone draws nigh to speak to her. 190 Wert thou to call the men of old time rude uncultured boors thou wouldst not err, seeing that they devised their hymns for festive occasions, for banquets, and to grace the board, a pleasure to catch the ear, shed o’er our life, 195 but no man hath found a way to allay hated grief by music and the minstrel’s varied strain, whence arise slaughters and fell strokes of fate to o’erthrow the homes of men. And yet this were surely a gain, 200 to heal men’s wounds by music’s spell, but why tune they their idle song where rich banquets are spread? for of itself doth the rich banquet, set before them, afford to men delight.

1.11

204 ἰαχὰν ἄιον πολύστονον γόων,
205 λιγυρὰ δ’ ἄχεα μογερὰ βοᾷ
206 τὸν ἐν λέχει προδόταν κακόνυμφον·

207 θεοκλυτεῖ δ’ ἄδικα παθοῦσα
208 τὰν Ζηνὸς ὁρκίαν Θέμιν,
209 ἅ νιν ἔβασεν
210 Ἑλλάδ’ ἐς ἀντίπορον
211 δι’ ἄλα νύχιον ἐφ’ ἁλμυρὰν
212 πόντου κλῇδ’ ἀπέραντον.
204 I heard a bitter cry of lamentation! 205 loudly, bitterly she calls on the traitor of her marriage bed, her perfidious spouse; by grievous wrongs oppressed she invokes Themis, bride of Zeus, witness of oaths, who brought her 210 unto Hellas, the land that fronts the strand of Asia, o’er the sea by night through ocean’s boundless gate.

1.1.357

357
358 φεῦ φεῦ, μελέα τῶν σῶν ἀχέων.
359 ποῖ ποτε τρέψῃ; τίνα πρὸς ξενίαν;
360 ἦ δόμον ἢ χθόνα σωτῆρα κακῶν
361 ἐξευρήσεις;
362 ὡς εἰς ἄπορόν σε κλύδωνα θεός,
363 Μήδεια, κακῶν ἐπόρευσε.
364 κακῶς πέπρακται πανταχῇ· τίς ἀντερεῖ;
365 ἀλλ’ οὔτι ταύτῃ ταῦτα, μὴ δοκεῖτέ πω.
366 ἔτ’ εἶσ’ ἀγῶνες τοῖς νεωστὶ νυμφίοις
367 καὶ τοῖσι κηδεύσασιν οὐ σμικροὶ πόνοι.
368 δοκεῖς γὰρ ἄν με τόνδε θωπεῦσαί ποτε,
369 εἰ μή τι κερδαίνουσαν ἢ τεχνωμένην;
370 οὐδ’ ἂν προσεῖπον οὐδ’ ἂν ἡψάμην χεροῖν.
371 ὃ δ’ ἐς τοσοῦτον μωρίας ἀφίκετο,
372 ὥστ’ ἐξὸν αὐτῷ τἄμ’ ἐλεῖν βουλεύματα
373 γῆς ἐκβαλόντι, τήνδ’ ἀφῆκεν ἡμέραν
374 μεῖναί μ’, ἐν ᾗ τρεῖς τῶν ἐμῶν ἐχθρῶν νεκροὺς
375 θήσω, πατέρα τε καὶ κόρην πόσιν τ’ ἐμόν.
376 πολλὰς δ’ ἔχουσα θανασίμους αὐτοῖς ὁδούς,
377 οὐκ οἶδ’ ὁποίᾳ πρῶτον ἐγχειρῶ, φίλαι·
378 πότερον ὑφάψω δῶμα νυμφικὸν πυρί,
379 ἢ θηκτὸν ὥσω φάσγανον δι’ ἥπατος,
380 σιγῇ δόμους ἐσβᾶσ’, ἵν’ ἔστρωται λέχος.
381 ἀλλ’ ἔν τί μοι πρόσαντες· εἰ ληφθήσομαι
382 δόμους ὑπεσβαίνουσα καὶ τεχνωμένη,
383 θανοῦσα θήσω τοῖς ἐμοῖς ἐχθροῖς γέλων.
384 κράτιστα τὴν εὐθεῖαν, ᾗ πεφύκαμεν
385 σοφαὶ μάλιστα, φαρμάκοις αὐτοὺς ἑλεῖν.
386 εἶέν·
357 Ah! poor lady, woe is thee! Alas, for thy sorrows! Whither wilt thou turn? What protection, 360 what home or country to save thee from thy troubles wilt thou find? O Medea, in what a hopeless sea of misery heaven hath plunged thee! 364 On all sides sorrow pens me in. Who shall gainsay this? 365 But all is not yet lost! think not so. Still are there troubles in store for the new bride, and for her bridegroom no light toil. Dost think I would ever have fawned on yonder man, unless to gain some end or form some scheme? 370 Nay, I would not so much as have spoken to him or touched him with my hand. But he has in folly so far stepped in that, though he might have checked my plot by banishing me from the land, he hath allowed me to abide this day, in which I will lay low in death three of my

enemies— 375 a father and his daughter and my husband too. Now, though I have many ways to compass their death, I am not sure, friends, which I am to try first. Shall I set fire to the bridal mansion, or plunge the whetted sword through their hearts, 380 softly stealing into the chamber where their couch is spread? One thing stands in my way. If I am caught making my way into the chamber, intent on my design, I shall be put to death and cause my foes to mock. 'Twere best to take the shortest way—the way we women are 385 most skilled in—by poison to destroy them. Well, well, suppose them dead; what city will receive me? What friendly host will give me a shelter in his land, a home secure, and save my soul alive? None. So I will wait yet a little while 390 in case some tower of defence rise up for me; then will I proceed to this bloody deed in crafty silence; but if some unexpected mischance drive me forth, I will with mine own hand seize the sword, e'en though I die for it, and slay them, and go forth on my bold path of daring. 395 By that dread queen whom I revere before all others and have chosen to share my task, by Hecate who dwells within my inmost chamber, not one of them shall wound my heart and rue it not. Bitter and sad will I make their marriage for them; 400 bitter shall be the wooing of it, bitter my exile from the land. Up, then, Medea, spare not the secrets of thy art in plotting and devising; on to the danger. Now comes a struggle needing courage. Dost see what thou art suffering? 'Tis not for thee to be a laughing-stock 405 to the race of Sisyphus by reason of this wedding of Jason, sprung, as thou art, from a noble sire, and of the Sun-god's race. Thou hast cunning; and, more than this, we women, though by nature little apt for virtuous deeds, are most expert to fashion any mischief.

1.1.386a

386a καὶ δὴ τεθνᾶσι· τίς με δέξεται πόλις;
387 τίς γῆν ἄσυλον καὶ δόμους ἐχεγγύους
388 ξένος παρασχὼν ῥύσεταί τοὐμὸν δέμας;
389 οὐκ ἔστι. μείνασ' οὖν ἔτι σμικρὸν χρόνον,
390 ἢν μέν τις ἡμῖν πύργος ἀσφαλὴς φανῇ,
391 δόλῳ μέτειμι τόνδε καὶ σιγῇ φόνον·
392 ἢν δ' ἐξελαύνῃ ξυμφορά μ' ἀμήχανος,
393 αὐτὴ ξίφος λαβοῦσα, κεἰ μέλλω θανεῖν,
394 κτενῶ σφε, τόλμης δ' εἶμι πρὸς τὸ καρτερόν.
395 οὐ γὰρ μὰ τὴν δέσποιναν ἣν ἐγὼ σέβω
396 μάλιστα πάντων καὶ ξυνεργὸν εἰλόμην,
397 Ἑκάτην, μυχοῖς ναίουσαν ἑστίας ἐμῆς,
398 χαίρων τις αὐτῶν τοὐμὸν ἀλγυνεῖ κέαρ.
399 πικροὺς δ' ἐγώ σφιν καὶ λυγροὺς θήσω γάμους,
400 πικρὸν δὲ κῆδος καὶ φυγὰς ἐμὰς χθονός.
401 ἀλλ' εἶα· φείδου μηδὲν ὧν ἐπίστασαι,
402 Μήδεια, βουλεύουσα καὶ τεχνωμένη·
403 ἕρπ' ἐς τὸ δεινόν· νῦν ἀγὼν εὐψυχίας.
404 ὁρᾷς ἃ πάσχεις· οὐ γέλωτα δεῖ σ' ὀφλεῖν
405 τοῖς Σισυφείοις τοῖς τ' Ἰάσονος γάμοις,
406 γεγῶσαν ἐσθλοῦ πατρὸς Ἡλίου τ' ἄπο.
407 ἐπίστασαι δέ· πρὸς δὲ καὶ πεφύκαμεν
408 γυναῖκες, ἐς μὲν ἔσθλ' ἀμηχανώταται,
409 κακῶν δὲ πάντων τέκτονες σοφώταται.

1.1

410 ἄνω ποταμῶν ἱερῶν χωροῦσι παγαί,

411 καὶ δίκα καὶ πάντα πάλιν στρέφεται.
412 ἀνδράσι μὲν δόλιαι βουλαί, θεῶν δ’
414 οὐκέτι πίστις ἄραρε·
415 τὰν δ’ ἐμὰν εὔκλειαν ἔχειν βιοτὰν στρέψουσι φᾶμαι·
419 ἔρχεται τιμὰ γυναικείῳ γένει·
420 οὐκέτι δυσκέλαδος φάμα γυναῖκας ἕξει.

1.1

421 μοῦσαι δὲ παλαιγενέων λήξουσ’ ἀοιδῶν
422 τὰν ἐμὰν ὑμνεῦσαι ἀπιστοσύναν.
423 οὐ γὰρ ἐν ἀμετέρᾳ γνώμᾳ λύρας
425 ὤπασε θέσπιν ἀοιδὰν
426 Φοῖβος, ἀγήτωρ μελέων· ἐπεὶ ἀντάχησ’ ἂν ὕμνον
427 ἀρσένων γέννᾳ. μακρὸς δ’ αἰὼν ἔχει
430 πολλὰ μὲν ἀμετέραν ἀνδρῶν τε μοῖραν εἰπεῖν.

1.2

431 σὺ δ’ ἐκ μὲν οἴκων πατρίων ἔπλευσας
432 μαινομένᾳ κραδίᾳ, διδύμους ὁρίσασα πόντου
433 πέτρας· ἐπὶ δὲ ξένᾳ
435 ναίεις χθονί, τᾶς ἀνάνδρου
436 κοίτας ὀλέσασα λέκτρον,
437 τάλαινα, φυγὰς δὲ χώρας
438 ἄτιμος ἐλαύνῃ.

1.2

439 βέβακε δ’ ὅρκων χάρις, οὐδ’ ἔτ’ αἰδὼς
440 Ἑλλάδι τᾷ μεγάλᾳ μένει, αἰθερία δ’ ἀνέπτα.
441 σοὶ δ’ οὔτε πατρὸς δόμοι,
442 δύστανε, μεθορμίσασθαι
443 μόχθων πάρα, τῶν τε λέκτρων
444 ἄλλα βασίλεια κρείσσων
445 δόμοισιν ἐπέστα.

1.446

446 οὐ νῦν κατεῖδον πρῶτον ἀλλὰ πολλάκις
447 τραχεῖαν ὀργὴν ὡς ἀμήχανον κακόν.
448 σοὶ γὰρ παρὸν γῆν τήνδε καὶ δόμους ἔχειν
449 κούφως φερούσῃ κρεισσόνων βουλεύματα,
450 λόγων ματαίων οὕνεκ’ ἐκπεσῇ χθονός.
451 κἀμοὶ μὲν οὐδὲν πρᾶγμα· μὴ παύσῃ ποτὲ
452 λέγουσ’ Ἰάσον’ ὡς κάκιστός ἐστ’ ἀνήρ·
453 ἃ δ’ ἐς τυράννους ἐστί σοι λελεγμένα,
454 πᾶν κέρδος ἡγοῦ ζημιουμένη φυγῇ.
455 κἀγὼ μὲν αἰεὶ βασιλέων θυμουμένων
456 ὀργὰς ἀφῄρουν καί σ’ ἐβουλόμην μένειν·
457 σὺ δ’ οὐκ ἀνίεις μωρίας, λέγουσ’ ἀεὶ
458 κακῶς τυράννους· τοιγὰρ ἐκπεσῇ χθονός.
459 ὅμως δὲ κἀκ τῶνδ’ οὐκ ἀπειρηκὼς φίλοις

460 ἥκω, τὸ σὸν δὲ προσκοπούμενος, γύναι,
461 ὡς μήτ’ ἀχρήμων σὺν τέκνοισιν ἐκπέσῃς
462 μήτ’ ἐνδεής του· πόλλ’ ἐφέλκεται φυγὴ
463 κακὰ ξὺν αὐτῇ. καὶ γὰρ εἰ σύ με στυγεῖς,
464 οὐκ ἂν δυναίμην σοὶ κακῶς φρονεῖν ποτε.
465 ὦ παγκάκιστε, τοῦτο γάρ σ’ εἰπεῖν ἔχω,
466 γλώσσῃ μέγιστον εἰς ἀνανδρίαν κακόν·
467 ἦλθες πρὸς ἡμᾶς, ἦλθες ἔχθιστος γεγώς;
468
469 οὔτοι θράσος τόδ’ ἐστὶν οὐδ’ εὐτολμία,
470 φίλους κακῶς δράσαντ’ ἐναντίον βλέπειν,
471 ἀλλ’ ἡ μεγίστη τῶν ἐν ἀνθρώποις νόσων
472 πασῶν, ἀναίδει’· εὖ δ’ ἐποίησας μολών·
473 ἐγώ τε γὰρ λέξασα κουφισθήσομαι
474 ψυχὴν κακῶς σε καὶ σὺ λυπήσῃ κλύων.
475 ἐκ τῶν δὲ πρώτων πρῶτον ἄρξομαι λέγειν.
446 It is not now I first remark, but oft ere this, how unruly a pest is a harsh temper. For instance, thou, hadst thou but patiently endured the will of thy superiors, mightest have remained here in this land and house, 450 but now for thy idle words wilt thou be banished. Thy words are naught to roe. Cease not to call Jason basest of men; but for those words thou hast spoken against our rulers, count it all gain that exile is thy only punishment. 455 I ever tried to check the outbursts of the angry monarch, and would have had thee stay, but thou wouldst not forego thy silly rage, always reviling our rulers, and so thou wilt be banished. Yet even after all this I weary not of my goodwill, 460 but am come with thus much forethought, lady, that thou mayst not be destitute nor want for aught, when, with thy sons, thou art cast out. Many an evil doth exile bring in its train with it; for even though thou hatest me, never will I harbour hard thoughts of thee. 465 Thou craven villain (for that is the only name my tongue can find for thee, a foul reproach on thy unmanliness)! comest thou to me, thou, most hated foe of gods, of me, and of all mankind? Tis no proof of courage or hardihood 470 to confront thy friends after injuring them, but that worst of all human diseases—loss of shame. Yet hast thou done well to come; for I shall ease ray soul by reviling thee, and thou wilt be vexed at my recital. 475 I will begin at the very beginning. I saved thy life, as every Hellene knows who sailed with thee aboard the good ship Argo, when thou wert sent to tame and yoke fire-breathing bulls, and to sow the deadly tilth. 480 Yea, and I slew the dragon which guarded the golden fleece, keeping sleepless watch o’er it with many a wreathed coil, and I raised for thee a beacon of deliver arice. Father and home of my free will I left and came with thee to Iolcos, ’neath Pelion’s hills, 485 for my love was stronger than my prudence. Next I caused the death of Pelias by a doom most grievous, even by his own children’s hand, beguiling them of all their fear. All this have I done for thee, thou traitor! and thou hast cast me over, taking to thyself another wife, 490 though children have been bom to us. Hadst thou been childless still, I could have pardoned thy desire for this new union. 492 Gone is now the trust I put in oaths. I cannot even understand whether thou thinkest that the gods of old no longer rule, or that fresh decrees are now in vogue amongst mankind, 495 for thy conscience must tell thee thou hast not kept faith with me. Ah! poor right hand, which thou didst often grasp. These knees thou didst embrace! All in vain, I suffered a traitor to touch me! How short of my hopes I am fallen! But come, I will deal with thee as though thou wert my friend. 500 Yet what kindness can I expect from one so base as thee? but yet I will do it, for my questioning will show thee yet more base. Whither can I turn me now? to my father’s house, to my own country, which I for thee deserted to come hither? to the hapless daughters of Pelias? A glad 505 welcome, I trow, would they give me in their home, whose father’s death I compassed! My case

stands even thus: I am become the bitter foe to those of mine own home, and those whom I need ne’er have wronged I have made mine enemies to pleasure thee. Wherefore to reward me for this thou hast made me doubly blest in the eyes of many a wife in Hellas; 510 and in thee I own a peerless, trusty lord. O woe is me, if indeed I am to be cast forth an exile from the land, without one friend; one lone woman with her babes forlorn! Yea, a fine reproach to thee in thy bridal hour, 515 that thy children and the wife who saved thy life are beggars and vagabonds! O Zeus! why hast thou granted unto man clear signs to know the sham in gold, white on man’s brow no brand is stamped whereby to gauge the villain’s heart? 520 There is a something terrible and past all cure, when quarrels arise ’twixt those who are near and dear. 522 Needs must I now, it seems, turn orator, and, like a good helmsman on a ship with close-reefed sails, weather 525 that wearisome tongue of thine. Now, I believe, since thou wilt exaggerate thy favours, that to Cypris alone of gods or men I owe the safety of my voyage. Thou hast a subtle wit enough; yet were it a hateful thing for me 530 to say that the Love-god constrained thee by his resistless shaft to save my life. However, I will not reckon this too nicely; ’twas kindly done, however thou didst serve me. Yet for my safety 535 hast thou received more than ever thou gavest, as I will show. First, thou dwellest in Hellas, instead of thy barbarian land, and hast learnt what justice means find how to live by law, not by the dictates of brute force; and all the Hellenes recognize thy cleverness, 540 and thou hast gained a name; whereas, if thou hadst dwelt upon the confines of the earth, no tongue had mentioned thee. Give me no gold within my halls; nor skill to sing a fairer strain than ever Orpheus sang, unless therewith my fame be spread abroad! 545 So much I say to thee about my own toils, for ’twas thou didst challenge me to this retort. As for the taunts thou urgest against my marriage with the princess, I will prove to thee, first, that I am prudent herein, next chastened in my love, and last a powerful friend 550 to thee and to thy sons; only hold thy peace. Since I have here withdrawn from Iolcos with many a hopeless trouble at my back, what happier device could I, an exile, frame than marriage with the daughter of the king? 555 ’Tis not because I loathe thee for my wife—the thought that rankles in thy heart; ’tis not because I am smitten with desire fot a new bride, nor yet that I am eager to vie with others in begetting many children, for those we have are quite enough, and I do not complain. Nay, ’tis that we—and this is most important— 560 may dwell in comfort, instead of suffering want (for well I know that every whilom friend avoids the poor), and that I might rear my sons as doth befit my house; further, that I might be the father of brothers for the children thou hast born, and raise these to the same high rank, uniting the family in one,— 565 to my lasting bliss. Thou, indeed, hast no need of more children, but me it profits to help my present family by that which is to be. Have I miscarried here? Not even thou wouldest say so unless a rival’s charms rankled in thy bosom. No, but you women have such strange ideas, 570 that you think all is well so long as your married life runs smooth; but if some mischance occur to ruffle your love, all that was good and lovely erst you reckon as your foes. Yea, men should have begotten children from some other source, no female race existing; 575 thus would no evil ever have fallen on mankind. 576 This speech, O Jason, hast thou with specious art arranged; but yet I think—albeit in saying so I betray indiscretion—that thou hast sinned in casting over thy wife.

1.476

476 ἔσῳσά σ’, ὡς ἴσασιν Ἑλλήνων ὅσοι
477 ταὐτὸν συνεισέβησαν Ἀργῷον σκάφος,
478 πεμφθέντα ταύρων πυρπνόων ἐπιστάτην
479 ζεύγλῃσι καὶ σπεροῦντα θανάσιμον γύην·
480 δράκοντά θ’, ὃς πάγχρυσον ἀμπέχων δέρας
481 σπείραις ἔσῳζε πολυπλόκοις ἄυπνος ὤν,

κτείνασ’ ἀνέσχον σοὶ φάος σωτήριον.
αὐτὴ δὲ πατέρα καὶ δόμους προδοῦσ’ ἐμοὺς
τὴν Πηλιῶτιν εἰς Ἰωλκὸν ἱκόμην
σὺν σοί, πρόθυμος μᾶλλον ἢ σοφωτέρα·
Πελίαν τ’ ἀπέκτειν’, ὥσπερ ἄλγιστον θανεῖν,
παίδων ὑπ’ αὐτοῦ, πάντα τ’ ἐξεῖλον δόμον.
καὶ ταῦθ’ ὑφ’ ἡμῶν, ὦ κάκιστ’ ἀνδρῶν, παθὼν
προύδωκας ἡμᾶς, καινὰ δ’ ἐκτήσω λέχη—
παίδων γεγώτων· εἰ γὰρ ἦσθ’ ἄπαις ἔτι,
συγγνώστ’ ἂν ἦν σοι τοῦδ’ ἐρασθῆναι λέχους.
ὅρκων δὲ φρούδη πίστις, οὐδ’ ἔχω μαθεῖν
ἢ θεοὺς νομίζεις τοὺς τότ’ οὐκ ἄρχειν ἔτι,
ἢ καινὰ κεῖσθαι θέσμι’ ἀνθρώποις τὰ νῦν,
ἐπεὶ σύνοισθά γ’ εἰς ἔμ’ οὐκ εὔορκος ὤν.
φεῦ δεξιὰ χείρ, ἧς σὺ πόλλ’ ἐλαμβάνου,
καὶ τῶνδε γονάτων, ὡς μάτην κεχρῴσμεθα
κακοῦ πρὸς ἀνδρός, ἐλπίδων δ’ ἡμάρτομεν.
ἄγ’· ὡς φίλῳ γὰρ ὄντι σοι κοινώσομαι
—δοκοῦσα μὲν τί πρός γε σοῦ πράξειν καλῶς;
ὅμως δ’· ἐρωτηθεὶς γὰρ αἰσχίων φανῇ—
νῦν ποῖ τράπωμαι; πότερα πρὸς πατρὸς δόμους,
οὓς σοὶ προδοῦσα καὶ πάτραν ἀφικόμην;
ἢ πρὸς ταλαίνας Πελιάδας; καλῶς γ’ ἂν οὖν
δέξαιντό μ’ οἴκοις ὧν πατέρα κατέκτανον.

1.506

ἔχει γὰρ οὕτω· τοῖς μὲν οἴκοθεν φίλοις
ἐχθρὰ καθέστηχ’, οὓς δέ μ’ οὐκ ἐχρῆν κακῶς
δρᾶν, σοὶ χάριν φέρουσα πολεμίους ἔχω.
τοιγάρ με πολλαῖς μακαρίαν Ἑλληνίδων
ἔθηκας ἀντὶ τῶνδε· θαυμαστὸν δέ σε
ἔχω πόσιν καὶ πιστὸν ἡ τάλαιν’ ἐγώ,
εἰ φεύξομαί γε γαῖαν ἐκβεβλημένη,
φίλων ἔρημος, σὺν τέκνοις μόνη μόνοις—
καλόν γ’ ὄνειδος τῷ νεωστὶ νυμφίῳ,
πτωχοὺς ἀλᾶσθαι παῖδας ἥ τ’ ἔσῳσά σε.
ὦ Ζεῦ, τί δὴ χρυσοῦ μὲν ὃς κίβδηλος ᾖ
τεκμήρι’ ἀνθρώποισιν ὥπασας σαφῆ,
ἀνδρῶν δ’ ὅτῳ χρὴ τὸν κακὸν διειδέναι,
οὐδεὶς χαρακτὴρ ἐμπέφυκε σώματι;
δεινή τις ὀργὴ καὶ δυσίατος πέλει,
ὅταν φίλοι φίλοισι συμβάλωσ’ ἔριν.
δεῖ μ’, ὡς ἔοικε, μὴ κακὸν φῦναι λέγειν,
ἀλλ’ ὥστε ναὸς κεδνὸν οἰακοστρόφον
ἄκροισι λαίφους κρασπέδοις ὑπεκδραμεῖν
τὴν σὴν στόμαργον, ὦ γύναι, γλωσσαλγίαν.
ἐγὼ δ’, ἐπειδὴ καὶ λίαν πυργοῖς χάριν,
Κύπριν νομίζω τῆς ἐμῆς ναυκληρίας
σώτειραν εἶναι θεῶν τε κἀνθρώπων μόνην.
σοὶ δ’ ἔστι μὲν νοῦς λεπτός—ἀλλ’ ἐπίφθονος
λόγος διελθεῖν, ὡς Ἔρως σ’ ἠνάγκασε

τόξοις ἀφύκτοις τοὐμὸν ἐκσῶσαι δέμας.
ἀλλ’ οὐκ ἀκριβῶς αὐτὸ θήσομαι λίαν·
ὅπῃ γὰρ οὖν ὤνησας, οὐ κακῶς ἔχει.
μείζω γε μέντοι τῆς ἐμῆς σωτηρίας
εἴληφας ἢ δέδωκας, ὡς ἐγὼ φράσω.

1.536

πρῶτον μὲν Ἑλλάδ’ ἀντὶ βαρβάρου χθονὸς
γαῖαν κατοικεῖς καὶ δίκην ἐπίστασαι
νόμοις τε χρῆσθαι μὴ πρὸς ἰσχύος χάριν·
πάντες δέ σ’ ᾔσθοντ’ οὖσαν Ἕλληνες σοφὴν
καὶ δόξαν ἔσχες· εἰ δὲ γῆς ἐπ’ ἐσχάτοις
ὅροισιν ᾤκεις, οὐκ ἂν ἦν λόγος σέθεν.
εἴη δ’ ἔμοιγε μήτε χρυσὸς ἐν δόμοις
μήτ’ Ὀρφέως κάλλιον ὑμνῆσαι μέλος,
εἰ μὴ ’πίσημος ἡ τύχη γένοιτό μοι.
τοσαῦτα μέν σοι τῶν ἐμῶν πόνων πέρι
ἔλεξ’· ἅμιλλαν γὰρ σὺ προύθηκας λόγων.
ἃ δ’ ἐς γάμους μοι βασιλικοὺς ὠνείδισας,
ἐν τῷδε δείξω πρῶτα μὲν σοφὸς γεγώς,
ἔπειτα σώφρων, εἶτα σοὶ μέγας φίλος
καὶ παισὶ τοῖς ἐμοῖσιν—ἀλλ’ ἔχ’ ἥσυχος.
ἐπεὶ μετέστην δεῦρ’ Ἰωλκίας χθονὸς
πολλὰς ἐφέλκων συμφορὰς ἀμηχάνους,
τί τοῦδ’ ἂν εὕρημ’ ἦλθον εὐτυχέστερον
ἢ παῖδα γῆμαι βασιλέως φυγὰς γεγώς;
οὐχ, ᾗ σὺ κνίζῃ, σὸν μὲν ἐχθαίρων λέχος,
καινῆς δὲ νύμφης ἱμέρῳ πεπληγμένος,
οὐδ’ εἰς ἅμιλλαν πολύτεκνον σπουδὴν ἔχων·
ἅλις γὰρ οἱ γεγῶτες οὐδὲ μέμφομαι·
ἀλλ’ ὡς, τὸ μὲν μέγιστον, οἰκοῖμεν καλῶς
καὶ μὴ σπανιζοίμεσθα, γιγνώσκων ὅτι
πένητα φεύγει πᾶς τις ἐκποδὼν φίλος,
παῖδας δὲ θρέψαιμ’ ἀξίως δόμων ἐμῶν
σπείρας τ’ ἀδελφοὺς τοῖσιν ἐκ σέθεν τέκνοις
ἐς ταὐτὸ θείην, καὶ ξυναρτήσας γένος
εὐδαιμονοῖμεν. σοί τε γὰρ παίδων τί δεῖ;

1.566

ἐμοί τε λύει τοῖσι μέλλουσιν τέκνοις
τὰ ζῶντ’ ὀνῆσαι. μῶν βεβούλευμαι κακῶς;
οὐδ’ ἂν σὺ φαίης, εἴ σε μὴ κνίζοι λέχος.
ἀλλ’ ἐς τοσοῦτον ἥκεθ’ ὥστ’ ὀρθουμένης
εὐνῆς γυναῖκες πάντ’ ἔχειν νομίζετε,
ἢν δ’ αὖ γένηται ξυμφορά τις ἐς λέχος,
τὰ λῷστα καὶ κάλλιστα πολεμιώτατα
τίθεσθε. χρῆν γὰρ ἄλλοθέν ποθεν βροτοὺς
παῖδας τεκνοῦσθαι, θῆλυ δ’ οὐκ εἶναι γένος·
χοὔτως ἂν οὐκ ἦν οὐδὲν ἀνθρώποις κακόν.
Ἰᾶσον, εὖ μὲν τούσδ’ ἐκόσμησας λόγους·

577 ὅμως δ’ ἔμοιγε, κεἰ παρὰ γνώμην ἐρῶ,
578 δοκεῖς προδοὺς σὴν ἄλοχον οὐ δίκαια δρᾶν.
579 ἦ πολλὰ πολλοῖς εἰμι διάφορος βροτῶν.
580 ἐμοὶ γὰρ ὅστις ἄδικος ὢν σοφὸς λέγειν
581 πέφυκε, πλείστην ζημίαν ὀφλισκάνει·
582 γλώσσῃ γὰρ αὐχῶν τἄδικ’ εὖ περιστελεῖν,
583 τολμᾷ πανουργεῖν· ἔστι δ’ οὐκ ἄγαν σοφός.
584 ὡς καὶ σὺ μή νυν εἰς ἔμ’ εὐσχήμων γένῃ
585 λέγειν τε δεινός. ἓν γὰρ ἐκτενεῖ σ’ ἔπος·
586 χρῆν σ’, εἴπερ ἦσθα μὴ κακός, πείσαντά με
587 γαμεῖν γάμον τόνδ’, ἀλλὰ μὴ σιγῇ φίλων.
588 καλῶς γ’ ἄν, οἶμαι, τῷδ’ ὑπηρέτεις λόγῳ,
589 εἴ σοι γάμον κατεῖπον, ἥτις οὐδὲ νῦν
590 τολμᾷς μεθεῖναι καρδίας μέγαν χόλον.
591 οὐ τοῦτό σ’ εἶχεν, ἀλλὰ βάρβαρον λέχος
592 πρὸς γῆρας οὐκ εὔδοξον ἐξέβαινέ σοι.
593 εὖ νῦν τόδ’ ἴσθι, μὴ γυναικὸς οὕνεκα
594 γῆμαί με λέκτρα βασιλέων ἃ νῦν ἔχω,
595 ἀλλ’, ὥσπερ εἶπον καὶ πάρος, σῶσαι θέλων
579 No doubt I differ from the mass of men on many points; 580 for, to my mind, whoso hath skill to fence with words in an unjust cause, incurs the heaviest penalty; for such an one, confident that he can cast a decent veil of words o’er his injustice, dares to practise it; and yet he is not so very clever after all. So do not thou put forth thy specious pleas 585 and clever words to me now, for one word of mine will lay thee low. Hadst thou not had a villain’s heart, thou shouldst have gained my consent, then made this match, instead of hiding it from those who loved thee. 588 Thou wouldest have lent me ready aid, no doubt, in this proposal, if I had told thee of my marriage, seeing that not even now 590 canst thou restrain thy soul’s hot fury. 591 This was not what restrained thee; but thine eye was turned towards old age, and a foreign wife began to appear discreditable to thee. 593 Be well assured of this: ’twas not for the woman’s sake I wedded the king’s daughter, my present wife; 595 but, as I have already told thee, I wished to insure thy safety and to be the father of royal sons bound by blood to my own children—a bulwark to our house. 598 May that prosperity, whose end is woe, ne’er be mine, nor such wealth as would ever sting my heart! 600 Change that prayer as I will teach thee, and thou wilt show more wisdom. Never let happiness appear in sorrow’s guise, nor, when thy fortune smiles, pretend she frowns! 603 Mock on; thou hast a place of refuge; I am alone, an exile soon to be. 605 Thy own free choice was this; blame no one else. 606 What did I do? Marry, then betray thee? 607 Against the king thou didst invoke an impious curse. 608 On thy house too maybe I bring the curse. 609 Know this, I will no further dispute this point with thee. 610 But, if thou wilt of my fortune somewhat take for the children or thyself to help thy exile, say on; for I am ready to grant it with ungrudging hand, yea and to send tokens to my friends elsewhere who shall treat thee well. If thou refuse this offer, thou wilt do a foolish deed, 615 but if thou cease from anger the greater will be thy gain. 616 I will have naught to do with friends of thine, naught will I receive of thee, offer it not to me; a villain’s gifts can bring no blessing. 619 At least I call the gods to witness, 620 that I am ready in all things to serve thee and thy children, but thou dost scorn my favours and thrustest thy friends stubbornly away; wherefore thy lot will be more bitter still. 623 Away! By love for thy young bride entrapped, too long thou lingerest outside her chamber; 625 go wed, for, if God will, thou shalt have such a marriage as thou wouldst fain refuse.

1.596

σέ, καὶ τέκνοισι τοῖς ἐμοῖς ὁμοσπόρους
φῦσαι τυράννους παῖδας, ἔρυμα δώμασι.
μή μοι γένοιτο λυπρὸς εὐδαίμων βίος
μηδ’ ὄλβος ὅστις τὴν ἐμὴν κνίζοι φρένα.
οἶσθ’ ὡς μέτευξαι, καὶ σοφωτέρα φανῇς;
τὰ χρηστὰ μή σοι λυπρὰ φαίνεσθαι ποτέ,
μηδ’ εὐτυχοῦσα δυστυχὴς εἶναι δοκεῖν.
ὕβριζ’, ἐπειδὴ σοὶ μὲν ἔστ’ ἀποστροφή,
ἐγὼ δ’ ἔρημος τήνδε φευξοῦμαι χθόνα.
αὐτὴ τάδ’ εἵλου· μηδέν’ ἄλλον αἰτιῶ.
τί δρῶσα; μῶν γαμοῦσα καὶ προδοῦσά σε;
ἀρὰς τυράννοις ἀνοσίους ἀρωμένη.
καὶ σοῖς ἀραία γ’ οὖσα τυγχάνω δόμοις.
ὡς οὐ κρινοῦμαι τῶνδέ σοι τὰ πλείονα.
ἀλλ’, εἴ τι βούλῃ παισὶν ἢ σαυτῆς φυγῇ
προσωφέλημα χρημάτων ἐμῶν λαβεῖν,
λέγ’· ὡς ἕτοιμος ἀφθόνῳ δοῦναι χερὶ
ξένοις τε πέμπειν σύμβολ’, οἳ δράσουσί σ’ εὖ.
καὶ ταῦτα μὴ θέλουσα μωρανεῖς, γύναι·
λήξασα δ’ ὀργῆς κερδανεῖς ἀμείνονα.
οὔτ’ ἂν ξένοισι τοῖσι σοῖς χρησαίμεθ’ ἄν,
οὔτ’ ἄν τι δεξαίμεσθα, μηδ’ ἡμῖν δίδου·
κακοῦ γὰρ ἀνδρὸς δῶρ’ ὄνησιν οὐκ ἔχει.
ἀλλ’ οὖν ἐγὼ μὲν δαίμονας μαρτύρομαι,
ὡς πάνθ’ ὑπουργεῖν σοί τε καὶ τέκνοις θέλω·
σοὶ δ’ οὐκ ἀρέσκει τἀγάθ’, ἀλλ’ αὐθαδίᾳ
φίλους ἀπωθῇ· τοιγὰρ ἀλγυνῇ πλέον.
χώρει· πόθῳ γὰρ τῆς νεοδμήτου κόρης
αἱρῇ χρονίζων δωμάτων ἐξώπιος.
νύμφευ’· ἴσως γάρ—σὺν θεῷ δ’ εἰρήσεται—

1.626

γαμεῖς τοιοῦτον ὥστε σ’ ἀρνεῖσθαι γάμον.

1.1

ἔρωτες ὑπὲρ μὲν ἄγαν
ἐλθόντες οὐκ εὐδοξίαν
οὐδ’ ἀρετὰν παρέδωκαν
ἀνδράσιν· εἰ δ’ ἄλις ἔλθοι
Κύπρις, οὐκ ἄλλα θεὸς εὔχαρις οὕτως.
μήποτ’, ὦ δέσποιν’, ἐπ’ ἐμοὶ χρυσέων τόξων ἐφείης
ἱμέρῳ χρίσασ’ ἄφυκτον οἰστόν.

1.1

στέργοι δέ με σωφροσύνα,
δώρημα κάλλιστον θεῶν·
μηδέ ποτ’ ἀμφιλόγους ὀργὰς
ἀκόρεστά τε νείκη
θυμὸν ἐκπλήξασ’ ἑτέροις ἐπὶ λέκτροις

προσβάλοι δεινὰ Κύπρις, ἀπτολέμους δ’ εὐνὰς σεβίζουσ’
ὀξύφρων κρίνοι λέχη γυναικῶν.

1.2

ὦ πατρίς, ὦ δώματα, μὴ
δῆτ’ ἄπολις γενοίμαν
τὸν ἀμηχανίας ἔχουσα
δυσπέρατον αἰῶν’,
οἰκτροτάτων ἀχέων.
θανάτῳ θανάτῳ πάρος δαμείην
ἀμέραν τάνδ’ ἐξανύσασα· μό-
χθων δ’ οὐκ ἄλλος ὕπερθεν ἢ
γᾶς πατρίας στέρεσθαι.

1.2

εἴδομεν, οὐκ ἐξ ἑτέρων
μῦθον ἔχω φράσασθαι·
σὲ γὰρ οὐ πόλις, οὐ φίλων τις
ᾤκτισεν παθοῦσαν
δεινότατον παθέων.
ἀχάριστος ὄλοιθ’, ὅτῳ πάρεστιν
μὴ φίλους τιμᾶν καθαρᾶν ἀνοί-
ξαντα κλῇδα φρενῶν· ἐμοὶ
μὲν φίλος οὔποτ’ ἔσται.

1.1.759

ἀλλά σ’ ὁ Μαίας πομπαῖος ἄναξ
πελάσειε δόμοις, ὧν τ’ ἐπίνοιαν
σπεύδεις κατέχων πράξειας, ἐπεὶ
γενναῖος ἀνήρ,
Αἰγεῦ, παρ’ ἐμοὶ δεδόκησαι.
ὦ Ζεῦ Δίκη τε Ζηνὸς Ἡλίου τε φῶς,
νῦν καλλίνικοι τῶν ἐμῶν ἐχθρῶν, φίλαι,
γενησόμεσθα κεἰς ὁδὸν βεβήκαμεν·
νῦν ἐλπὶς ἐχθροὺς τοὺς ἐμοὺς τείσειν δίκην.
οὗτος γὰρ ἀνὴρ ᾗ μάλιστ’ ἐκάμνομεν
λιμὴν πέφανται τῶν ἐμῶν βουλευμάτων·
ἐκ τοῦδ’ ἀναψόμεσθα πρυμνήτην κάλων,
μολόντες ἄστυ καὶ πόλισμα Παλλάδος.
ἤδη δὲ πάντα τἀμά σοι βουλεύματα
λέξω· δέχου δὲ μὴ πρὸς ἡδονὴν λόγους.
πέμψασ’ ἐμῶν τιν’ οἰκετῶν Ἰάσονα
ἐς ὄψιν ἐλθεῖν τὴν ἐμὴν αἰτήσομαι·
μολόντι δ’ αὐτῷ μαλθακοὺς λέξω λόγους,
ὡς καὶ δοκεῖ μοι ταὐτά, καὶ καλῶς ἔχειν
γάμους τυράννων οὓς προδοὺς ἡμᾶς ἔχει·
καὶ ξύμφορ’ εἶναι καὶ καλῶς ἐγνωσμένα.
παῖδας δὲ μεῖναι τοὺς ἐμοὺς αἰτήσομαι,
οὐχ ὡς λιποῦσ’ ἂν πολεμίας ἐπὶ χθονὸς
ἐχθροῖσι παῖδας τοὺς ἐμοὺς καθυβρίσαι,

783 ἀλλ’ ὡς δόλοισι παῖδα βασιλέως κτάνω.
784 πέμψω γὰρ αὐτοὺς δῶρ’ ἔχοντας ἐν χεροῖν,
785 νύμφῃ φέροντας, τήνδε μὴ φυγεῖν χθόνα,
786 λεπτόν τε πέπλον καὶ πλόκον χρυσήλατον·
787 κἄνπερ λαβοῦσα κόσμον ἀμφιθῇ χροΐ,
788 κακῶς ὀλεῖται πᾶς θ’ ὃς ἂν θίγῃ κόρης·
759 May Maia’s princely son 760 go with thee on thy way to bring thee to thy home, and mayest thou attain that on which thy soul is set so firmly, for to my mind thou seemest a generous man, O Aegeus. 764 O Zeus, and Justice, child of Zeus, and sun-god’s light, 765 now will I triumph o’er my foes, kind friends; on victory’s road have I set forth; good hope have I of wreaking vengeance on those I hate. For where we were in most distress this stranger hath appeared, to be a haven in my counsels; 770 to him will we make fast the cables of our ship when we come to the town and citadel of Pallas. But now will I explain to thee my plans in full; do not expect to hear a pleasant tale. A servant of mine will I to Jason 775 send and crave an interview; then when he comes I will address him with soft words, say, this pleases me, and, that is well, ; 780 then will I entreat that here my children may abide, not that I mean to leave them in a hostile land for foes to flout, but that I may slay the king’s daughter by guile. For I will send them with gifts in their hands, 785 carrying them unto the bride to save them from banishment, a robe of finest woof and a chaplet of gold. And if these ornaments she take and put them on, miserably shall she die, and likewise everyone who touches her; with such fell poisons will I smear my gifts. 790 And here I quit this theme; but I shudder at the deed I must do next; for I will slay the children I have borne; there is none shall take them from my toils; and when I have utterly confounded Jason’s house 795 I will leave the land, escaping punishment for my dear children’s murder, after my most unholy deed. For I cannot endure the taunts of enemies, kind friends; enough! what gain is life to me? I have no country, home, or refuge left. 800 O, I did wrong, that hour I left my father’s home, persuaded by that Hellene’s words, who now shall pay the penalty, so help me God. Never shall he see again alive the children I bore to him, 805 nor from his new bride shall he beget issue, for she must die a hideous death, slain by my drugs. Let no one deem me a poor weak woman who sits with folded hands, but of another mould, dangerous to foes and well-disposed to friends; 810 for they win the fairest fame who live their life like me. 811 Since thou hast imparted this design to me, I bid thee hold thy hand, both from a wish to serve thee and because I would uphold the laws men make. 814 It cannot but be so; thy words 815 I pardon since thou art not in the same sorry plight that I am. 816 O lady, wilt thou steel thyself to slay thy children twain? 817 I will, for that will stab my husband to the heart. 818 It may, but thou wilt be the saddest wife alive. 819 No matter; wasted is every word that comes ’twixt now and then. 820 (To the Nurse.) Ho! thou, go call me Jason hither, for thee I do employ on every mission of trust. No word divulge of all my purpose, as thou art to thy mistress loyal and likewise of my sex.

1.1.789

789 τοιοῖσδε χρίσω φαρμάκοις δωρήματα.
790 ἐνταῦθα μέντοι τόνδ’ ἀπαλλάσσω λόγον·
791 ὤμωξα δ’ οἷον ἔργον ἔστ’ ἐργαστέον
792 τοὐντεῦθεν ἡμῖν· τέκνα γὰρ κατακτενῶ
793 τἄμ’· οὔτις ἔστιν ὅστις ἐξαιρήσεται·
794 δόμον τε πάντα συγχέας’ Ἰάσονος
795 ἔξειμι γαίας, φιλτάτων παίδων φόνον
796 φεύγουσα καὶ τλᾶσ’ ἔργον ἀνοσιώτατον.
797 οὐ γὰρ γελᾶσθαι τλητὸν ἐξ ἐχθρῶν, φίλαι.

798 ἴτω· τί μοι ζῆν κέρδος; οὔτε μοι πατρὶς
799 οὔτ’ οἶκος ἔστιν οὔτ’ ἀποστροφὴ κακῶν.
800 ἡμάρτανον τόθ’ ἡνίκ’ ἐξελίμπανον
801 δόμους πατρῴους, ἀνδρὸς Ἕλληνος λόγοις
802 πεισθεῖσ’, ὃς ἡμῖν σὺν θεῷ τείσει δίκην.
803 οὔτ’ ἐξ ἐμοῦ γὰρ παῖδας ὄψεταί ποτε
804 ζῶντας τὸ λοιπὸν οὔτε τῆς νεοζύγου
805 νύμφης τεκνώσει παῖδ’, ἐπεὶ κακῶς κακὴν
806 θανεῖν σφ’ ἀνάγκη τοῖς ἐμοῖσι φαρμάκοις.
807 μηδείς με φαύλην κἀσθενῆ νομιζέτω
808 μηδ’ ἡσυχαίαν, ἀλλὰ θατέρου τρόπου,
809 βαρεῖαν ἐχθροῖς καὶ φίλοισιν εὐμενῆ·
810 τῶν γὰρ τοιούτων εὐκλεέστατος βίος.
811 ἐπείπερ ἡμῖν τόνδ’ ἐκοίνωσας λόγον,
812 σέ τ’’ ὠφελεῖν θέλουσα, καὶ νόμοις βροτῶν
813 ξυλλαμβάνουσα, δρᾶν σ’ ἀπεννέπω τάδε.
814 οὐκ ἔστιν ἄλλως· σοὶ δὲ συγγνώμη λέγειν
815 τάδ’ ἐστί, μὴ πάσχουσαν, ὡς ἐγώ, κακῶς.
816 ἀλλὰ κτανεῖν σὸν σπέρμα τολμήσεις, γύναι;
817 οὕτω γὰρ ἂν μάλιστα δηχθείη πόσις.
818 σὺ δ’ ἂν γένοιό γ’ ἀθλιωτάτη γυνή.

1.1.819

819 ἴτω· περισσοὶ πάντες οὐν μέσῳ λόγοι.
820 ἀλλ’ εἶα χώρει καὶ κόμιζ’ Ἰάσονα·
821 ἐς πάντα γὰρ δὴ σοὶ τὰ πιστὰ χρώμεθα.
822 λέξῃς δὲ μηδὲν τῶν ἐμοὶ δεδογμένων,
823 εἴπερ φρονεῖς εὖ δεσπόταις γυνή τ’ ἔφυς.

1.1

824 Ἐρεχθεΐδαι τὸ παλαιὸν ὄλβιοι
825 καὶ θεῶν παῖδες μακάρων, ἱερᾶς
826 χώρας ἀπορθήτου τ’ ἄπο, φερβόμενοι
827 κλεινοτάταν σοφίαν, αἰεὶ διὰ λαμπροτάτου
830 βαίνοντες ἁβρῶς αἰθέρος, ἔνθα ποθ’ ἁγνὰς
831 ἐννέα Πιερίδας Μούσας λέγουσι
832 ξανθὰν Ἁρμονίαν φυτεῦσαι·

1.1

835 τοῦ καλλινάου τ’ ἐπὶ Κηφισοῦ ῥοαῖς
836 τὰν Κύπριν κλήζουσιν ἀφυσσαμέναν
837 χώραν καταπνεῦσαι μετρίας ἀνέμων
840 ἡδυπνόους αὔρας· αἰεὶ δ’ ἐπιβαλλομέναν
841 χαίταισιν εὐώδη ῥοδέων πλόκον ἀνθέων
842 τᾷ Σοφίᾳ παρέδρους πέμπειν Ἔρωτας,
845 παντοίας ἀρετᾶς ξυνεργούς.

1.2

846 πῶς οὖν ἱερῶν ποταμῶν

ἢ πόλις; ἦ φίλων
πόμπιμός σε χώρα
τὰν παιδολέτειραν ἔξει,
τὰν οὐχ ὁσίαν μετ’ ἄλλων;
σκέψαι τεκέων πλαγάν,
σκέψαι φόνον οἷον αἴρῃ.
μή, πρὸς γονάτων σε πάντη
πάντως ἱκετεύομεν,
τέκνα φονεύσῃς.

1.2

πόθεν θράσος ἢ φρενὸς ἢ
χειρὶ τέκνων σέθεν
καρδίᾳ τε λήψῃ
δεινὰν προσάγουσα τόλμαν;
πῶς δ’ ὄμματα προσβαλοῦσα
τέκνοις ἄδακρυν μοῖραν
σχήσεις φόνου; οὐ δυνάσῃ,
παίδων ἱκετᾶν πιτνόντων,
τέγξαι χέρα φοινίαν
τλάμονι θυμῷ.

1.866

ἥκω κελευσθείς· καὶ γὰρ οὖσα δυσμενὴς
οὔ τἂν ἁμάρτοις τοῦδέ γ’, ἀλλ’ ἀκούσομαι
τί χρῆμα βούλῃ καινὸν ἐξ ἐμοῦ, γύναι.
Ἰᾶσον, αἰτοῦμαί σε τῶν εἰρημένων
συγγνώμον’ εἶναι· τὰς δ’ ἐμὰς ὀργὰς φέρειν
εἰκός σ’, ἐπεὶ νῷν πόλλ’ ὑπείργασται φίλα.
ἐγὼ δ’ ἐμαυτῇ διὰ λόγων ἀφικόμην
κἀλοιδόρησα· Σχετλία, τί μαίνομαι
καὶ δυσμεναίνω τοῖσι βουλεύουσιν εὖ,
ἐχθρὰ δὲ γαίας κοιράνοις καθίσταμαι
πόσει θ’, ὃς ἡμῖν δρᾷ τὰ συμφορώτατα,
γήμας τύραννον καὶ κασιγνήτους τέκνοις
ἐμοῖς φυτεύων; οὐκ ἀπαλλαχθήσομαι
θυμοῦ—τί πάσχω;—θεῶν ποριζόντων καλῶς;
οὐκ εἰσὶ μέν μοι παῖδες, οἶδα δὲ χθόνα
φεύγοντας ἡμᾶς καὶ σπανίζοντας φίλων;
ταῦτ’ ἐννοήσασ’ ᾐσθόμην ἀβουλίαν
πολλὴν ἔχουσα καὶ μάτην θυμουμένη.
νῦν οὖν ἐπαινῶ· σωφρονεῖν τ’ ἐμοὶ δοκεῖς
κῆδος τόδ’ ἡμῖν προσλαβών, ἐγὼ δ’ ἄφρων,
ᾗ χρῆν μετεῖναι τῶνδε τῶν βουλευμάτων,
καὶ ξυγγαμεῖν σοι, καὶ παρεστάναι λέχει
νύμφην τε κηδεύουσαν ἥδεσθαι σέθεν.
ἀλλ’ ἐσμὲν οἷόν ἐσμεν, οὐκ ἐρῶ κακόν,
γυναῖκες· οὔκουν χρῆν σ’ ὁμοιοῦσθαι κακοῖς,
οὐδ’ ἀντιτείνειν νήπι’ ἀντὶ νηπίων.
παριέμεσθα, καί φαμεν κακῶς φρονεῖν

893 τότ’, ἀλλ’ ἄμεινον νῦν βεβούλευμαι τάδε·
894 ὦ τέκνα τέκνα, δεῦτε, λείπετε στέγας,
895 ἐξέλθετ’, ἀσπάσασθε καὶ προσείπατε
866 I am come at thy bidding, for e’en though thy hate for me is bitter thou shalt not fail in this small boon, but I will hear what new request thou hast to make of me, lady. 869 Jason, I crave thy pardon 870 for the words I spoke, and well thou mayest brook my burst of passion, for ere now we twain have shared much love. For I have reasoned with my soul and railed upon me thus, Ah! poor heart 1 why am I thus distraught, why so angered ’gainst all good advice, 875 why have I come to hate the rulers of the land, my husband too, who does the best for me he can, in wedding with a princess and rearing for my children noble brothers? Shall I not cease to fret? What possesses me, when heaven its best doth offer? 880 Have I not my children to consider? do I forget that we are fugitives, in need of friends? When I had thought all this I saw how foolish I had been, how senselessly enraged. So now I do commend thee and think thee most wise in forming 885 this connexion for us; but I was mad, I who should have shared in these designs, helped on thy plans, and lent my aid to bring about the match, only too pleased to wait upon thy bride. But what we are, we are, we women, evil I will not say; 890 wherefore thou shouldst not sink to our sorry level nor with our weapons meet our childishness. 892 I yield and do confess that I was wrong then, but now have I come to a better mind. Come hither, my children, come, leave the house, 895 step forth, and with me greet and bid farewell to your father, be reconciled from all past bitterness unto your friends, as now your mother is; for we have made a truce and anger is no more. Enter the Children. Take his right hand; ah me! my sad fate! 900 when I reflect, as now, upon the hidden future. O my children, since there awaits you even thus a long, long life, stretch forth the hand to take a fond farewell. Ah me! how new to tears am I, how full of fear! For now that I have at last released me from my quarrel with your father, 905 I let the tear-drops stream adown my tender cheek. 906 From my eyes too bursts forth the copious tear; O, may no greater ill than the present e’er befall! 908 Lady, I praise this conduct, not that I blame what is past; for it is but natural to the female sex to vent their spleen against a husband 910 when he trafficks in other marriages besides his own. But thy heart is changed to wiser schemes and thou art determined on the better course, late though it be; this is acting like a woman of sober sense. And for you, my sons, hath your father provided 915 with all good heed a sure refuge, by God’s grace; for ye, I trow, shall with your brothers share hereafter the foremost rank in this Corinthian realm. Only grow up, for all the rest your sire and whoso of the gods is kind to us is bringing to pass. 920 May I see you reach man’s full estate, high o’er the heads of those I hate! But thou, lady, why with fresh tears dost thou thine eyelids wet, turning away thy wan cheek, with no welcome for these my happy tidings? 925 ’Tis naught; upon these children my thoughts were turned. 926 Then take heart; for I will see that it is well with them. 927 I will do so; nor will I doubt thy word; woman is a weak creature, ever given to tears. 929 Why prithee, unhappy one, dost moan o’er these children? 930 I gave them birth; and when thou didst pray long life for them, pity entered into my soul to think that these things must be. But the reason of thy coming hither to speak with me is partly told, the rest will I now mention. Since it is the pleasure of the rulers of the land to banish me, 935 and well I know ’twere best for me to stand not in the way of thee or of the rulers by dwelling here, enemy as I am thought unto their house, forth from this land in exile am I going, but these children,—that they may know thy fostering hand, 940 beg Creon to remit their banishment 941 I doubt whether I can persuade him, yet must I attempt it. 942 At least do thou bid thy wife ask her sire this boon, to remit the exile of the children from this land. 944 Yea, that will I; and her methinks I shall persuade, 945 since she is a woman like the rest. 946 I too will aid thee in this task, for by the children’s hand I will send to her gifts that far surpass in beauty, I well know, aught that now is seen ’mongst men, a robe of finest tissue and a chaplet of chased gold.

950 But one of my attendants must haste and bring the ornaments hither. Happy shall she be not once alone but ten thousandfold, for in thee she wins the noblest soul to share her love, and gets these gifts as well which on a day my father’s sire, the Sun-god, 955 bestowed on his descendants. My children, take in your hands these wedding gifts, and bear them as an offering to the royal maid, the happy bride; for verily the gifts she shall receive are not to be scorned. 959 But why so rashly rob thyself of these gifts? 960 Dost think a royal palace wants for robes or gold? Keep them, nor give them to another. For well I know that if my lady hold me in esteem, she will set my price above all wealth. 964 Say not so; ’tis said that gifts tempt even gods; 965 and o’er men’s minds gold holds more potent sway than countless words. Fortune smiles upon thy bride, and heaven now doth swell her triumph; youth is hers and princely power; yet to save my children from exile I would barter life, not dross alone. Children, when ye are come to the rich palace, 970 pray your father’s new bride, my mistress, with suppliant voice to save you from exile, offering her these ornaments the while; for it is most needful that she receive the gifts in her own hand. Now go and linger not; may ye succeed and to your mother bring back 975 the glad tidings she fain would hear!

1.896

896 πατέρα μεθ’ ἡμῶν, καὶ διαλλάχθηθ’ ἅμα
897 τῆς πρόσθεν ἔχθρας ἐς φίλους μητρὸς μέτα·
898 σπονδαὶ γὰρ ἡμῖν καὶ μεθέστηκεν χόλος.
899 λάβεσθε χειρὸς δεξιᾶς· οἴμοι, κακῶν
900 ὡς ἐννοοῦμαι δή τι τῶν κεκρυμμένων.
901 ἆρ’, ὦ τέκν’, οὕτω καὶ πολὺν ζῶντες χρόνον
902 φίλην ὀρέξετ’ ὠλένην; τάλαιν’ ἐγώ,
903 ὡς ἀρτίδακρύς εἰμι καὶ φόβου πλέα.
904 χρόνῳ δὲ νεῖκος πατρὸς ἐξαιρουμένη
905 ὄψιν τέρειναν τήνδ’ ἔπλησα δακρύων.
906 κἀμοὶ κατ’ ὄσσων χλωρὸν ὡρμήθη δάκρυ·
907 καὶ μὴ προβαίη μεῖζον ἢ τὸ νῦν κακόν.
908 αἰνῶ, γύναι, τάδ’, οὐδ’ ἐκεῖνα μέμφομαι·
909 εἰκὸς γὰρ ὀργὰς θῆλυ ποιεῖσθαι γένος
910 γάμου παρεμπολῶντος ἀλλοίου πόσει.
911 ἀλλ’ ἐς τὸ λῷον σὸν μεθέστηκεν κέαρ,
912 ἔγνως δὲ τὴν νικῶσαν, ἀλλὰ τῷ χρόνῳ,
913 βουλήν· γυναικὸς ἔργα ταῦτα σώφρονος.
914 ὑμῖν δέ, παῖδες, οὐκ ἀφροντίστως πατὴρ
915 πολλὴν ἔθηκε σὺν θεοῖς σωτηρίαν·
916 οἶμαι γὰρ ὑμᾶς τῆσδε γῆς Κορινθίας
917 τὰ πρῶτ’ ἔσεσθαι σὺν κασιγνήτοις ἔτι.
918 ἀλλ’ αὐξάνεσθε· τἄλλα δ’ ἐξεργάζεται
919 πατήρ τε καὶ θεῶν ὅστις ἐστὶν εὐμενής·
920 ἴδοιμι δ’ ὑμᾶς εὐτραφεῖς ἥβης τέλος
921 μολόντας, ἐχθρῶν τῶν ἐμῶν ὑπερτέρους.
922 αὕτη, τί χλωροῖς δακρύοις τέγγεις κόρας,
923 στρέψασα λευκὴν ἔμπαλιν παρηίδα;
924 κοὐκ ἀσμένη τόνδ’ ἐξ ἐμοῦ δέχῃ λόγον;
925 οὐδέν. τέκνων τῶνδ’ ἐννοουμένη πέρι.

1.926

θάρσει νυν· εὖ γὰρ τῶνδ’ ἐγὼ θήσω πέρι.
δράσω τάδ’· οὗτοι σοῖς ἀπιστήσω λόγοις·
γυνὴ δὲ θῆλυ κἀπὶ δακρύοις ἔφυ.
τί δῆτα λίαν τοῖσδ’ ἐπιστένεις τέκνοις;
ἔτικτον αὐτούς· ζῆν δ’ ὅτ’ ἐξηύχου τέκνα,
ἐσῆλθέ μ’ οἶκτος εἰ γενήσεται τάδε.
ἀλλ’ ὧνπερ οὕνεκ’ εἰς ἐμοὺς ἥκεις λόγους,
τὰ μὲν λέλεκται, τῶν δ’ ἐγὼ μνησθήσομαι.
ἐπεὶ τυράννοις γῆς μ’ ἀποστεῖλαι δοκεῖ—
κἀμοὶ τάδ’ ἐστὶ λῷστα, γιγνώσκω καλῶς,
μήτ’ ἐμποδὼν σοὶ μήτε κοιράνοις χθονὸς
ναίειν· δοκῶ γὰρ δυσμενὴς εἶναι δόμοις—
ἡμεῖς μὲν ἐκ γῆς τῆσδ’ ἀπαίρομεν φυγῇ,
παῖδες δ’ ὅπως ἂν ἐκτραφῶσι σῇ χερί,
αἰτοῦ Κρέοντα τήνδε μὴ φεύγειν χθόνα.
οὐκ οἶδ’ ἂν εἰ πείσαιμι, πειρᾶσθαι δὲ χρή.
σὺ δ’ ἀλλὰ σὴν κέλευσον αἰτεῖσθαι πατρὸς
γυναῖκα παῖδας τήνδε μὴ φεύγειν χθόνα.
μάλιστα, καὶ πείσειν γε δοξάζω σφ’ ἐγώ.
εἴπερ γυναικῶν ἐστι τῶν ἄλλων μία.
συλλήψομαι δὲ τοῦδέ σοι κἀγὼ πόνου·
πέμψω γὰρ αὐτῇ δῶρ’ ἃ καλλιστεύεται
τῶν νῦν ἐν ἀνθρώποισιν, οἶδ’ ἐγώ, πολύ,
λεπτόν τε πέπλον καὶ πλόκον χρυσήλατον
παῖδας φέροντας. ἀλλ’ ὅσον τάχος χρεὼν
κόσμον κομίζειν δεῦρο προσπόλων τινά.
εὐδαιμονήσει δ’ οὐχ ἕν, ἀλλὰ μυρία,
ἀνδρός τ’ ἀρίστου σοῦ τυχοῦσ’ ὀμευνέτου
κεκτημένη τε κόσμον ὅν ποθ’ Ἥλιος
πατρὸς πατὴρ δίδωσιν ἐκγόνοισιν οἷς.

1.956

λάζυσθε φερνὰς τάσδε, παῖδες, ἐς χέρας
καὶ τῇ τυράννῳ μακαρίᾳ νύμφῃ δότε
φέροντες· οὗτοι δῶρα μεμπτὰ δέξεται.
τί δ’, ὦ ματαία, τῶνδε σὰς κενοῖς χέρας;
δοκεῖς σπανίζειν δῶμα βασίλειον πέπλων,
δοκεῖς δὲ χρυσοῦ; σῷζε, μὴ δίδου τάδε.
εἴπερ γὰρ ἡμᾶς ἀξιοῖ λόγου τινὸς
γυνή, προθήσει χρημάτων, σάφ’ οἶδ’ ἐγώ.
μή μοι σύ· πείθειν δῶρα καὶ θεοὺς λόγος·
χρυσὸς δὲ κρείσσων μυρίων λόγων βροτοῖς.
κείνης ὁ δαίμων, κεῖνα νῦν αὔξει θεός,
νέα τυραννεῖ· τῶν δ’ ἐμῶν παίδων φυγὰς
ψυχῆς ἂν ἀλλαξαίμεθ’, οὐ χρυσοῦ μόνον.
ἀλλ’, ὦ τέκν’, εἰσελθόντε πλουσίους δόμους
πατρὸς νέαν γυναῖκα, δεσπότιν δ’ ἐμήν,
ἱκετεύετ’, ἐξαιτεῖσθε μὴ φυγεῖν χθόνα,
κόσμον διδόντες—τοῦδε γὰρ μάλιστα δεῖ—
ἐς χεῖρ’ ἐκείνης δῶρα δέξασθαι τάδε.

974 ἴθ’ ὡς τάχιστα· μητρὶ δ’ ὧν ἐρᾷ τυχεῖν
975 εὐάγγελοι γένοισθε πράξαντες καλῶς.

1.1

976 νῦν ἐλπίδες οὐκέτι μοι παίδων ζόας,
977 οὐκέτι· στείχουσι γὰρ ἐς φόνον ἤδη.
978 δέξεται νύμφα χρυσέων ἀναδεσμῶν
979 δέξεται δύστανος ἅταν·
980 ξανθᾷ δ’ ἀμφὶ κόμᾳ θήσει τὸν Ἅιδα
981 κόσμον αὐτὰ χεροῖν.

1.1

983 πείσει χάρις ἀμβρόσιός τ’ αὐγὰ πέπλων
984 χρυσέων τευκτὸν στέφανον περιθέσθαι·
985 νερτέροις δ’ ἤδη πάρα νυμφοκομήσει.
986 τοῖον εἰς ἔρκος πεσεῖται
987 καὶ μοῖραν θανάτου δύστανος· ἅταν δ’
988 οὐχ ὑπεκφεύξεται.

1.2

990 σὺ δ’, ὦ τάλαν, ὦ κακόνυμφε κηδεμὼν τυράννων,
991 παισὶν οὐ κατειδὼς
992 ὄλεθρον βιοτᾷ προσάγεις ἀλόχῳ τε
993 σᾷ στυγερὸν θάνατον.
995 δύστανε μοίρας ὅσον παροίχῃ.

1.2

996 μεταστένομαι δὲ σὸν ἄλγος, ὦ τάλαινα παίδων
997 μᾶτερ, ἃ φονεύσεις
998 τέκνα νυμφιδίων ἕνεκεν λεχέων, ἄ
1000 σοι προλιπὼν ἀνόμως
1001 ἄλλᾳ ξυνοικεῖ πόσις συνεύνῳ.

1.1.1081

1081 πολλάκις ἤδη
1082 διὰ λεπτοτέρων μύθων ἔμολον
1083 καὶ πρὸς ἀμίλλας ἦλθον μείζους
1084 ἢ χρὴ γενεὰν θῆλυν ἐρευνᾶν·
1085 ἀλλὰ γὰρ ἔστιν μοῦσα καὶ ἡμῖν,
1086 ἢ προσομιλεῖ σοφίας ἕνεκεν·
1087 πάσαισι μὲν οὔ· παῦρον δὲ δὴ
1088 γένος ἐν πολλαῖς εὔροις ἂν ἴσως
1089 κοὐκ ἀπόμουσον τὸ γυναικῶν.
1090 καί φημι βροτῶν οἵτινές εἰσιν
1091 πάμπαν ἄπειροι μηδ’ ἐφύτευσαν
1092 παῖδας, προφέρειν εἰς εὐτυχίαν
1093 τῶν γειναμένων.
1094 οἱ μὲν ἄτεκνοι δι’ ἀπειροσύνην
1095 εἴθ’ ἡδὺ βροτοῖς εἴτ’ ἀνιαρὸν

1096 παῖδες τελέθουσ’ οὐχὶ τυχόντες
1097 πολλῶν μόχθων ἀπέχονται·
1098 οἷσι δὲ τέκνων ἔστιν ἐν οἴκοις
1099 γλυκερὸν βλάστημ’, ὁρῶ μελέτῃ
1100 κατατρυχομένους τὸν ἅπαντα χρόνον,
1101 πρῶτον μὲν ὅπως θρέψουσι καλῶς
1102 βίοτόν θ’ ὁπόθεν λείψουσι τέκνοις·
1103 ἔτι δ’ ἐκ τούτων εἴτ’ ἐπὶ φλαύροις
1104 εἴτ’ ἐπὶ χρηστοῖς
1104a μοχθοῦσι, τόδ’ ἐστὶν ἄδηλον.
1105 ἓν δὲ τὸ πάντων λοίσθιον ἤδη
1106 πᾶσιν κατερῶ θνητοῖσι κακόν·
1107 καὶ δὴ γὰρ ἅλις βίοτόν θ’ ηὗρον
1108 σῶμά τ’ ἐς ἥβην ἤλυθε τέκνων
1109 χρηστοί τ’ ἐγένοντ’· εἰ δὲ κυρήσαι
1081 Oft ere now have I pursued subtler themes and have faced graver issues than woman’s sex should seek to probe; 1085 but then e’en we aspire to culture, which dwells with us to teach us wisdom; I say not all; for small is the class amongst women—(one maybe shalt thou find ’mid many)— that is not incapable of culture. 1090 And amongst mortals I do assert that they who are wholly without experience and have never had children far surpass in happiness those who are parents. The childless, because they have never proved 1095 whether children grow up to be a blessing or curse to men are removed from all share in many troubles; whilst those who have a sweet race of children growing up in their houses do wear away, as I perceive, 1100 their whole life through; first with the thought how they may train them up in virtue, next how they shall leave their sons the means to live; and after all this ’tis far from clear whether on good or bad children they bestow their toil. 1105 But one last crowning woe for every mortal man I now will name; suppose that they have found sufficient means to live, and seen their children grow to man’s estate and walk in virtue’s path, still if 1110 fortune so befall, comes Death and bears the children’s bodies off to Hades. Can it be any profit to the gods to heap upon us mortal men beside our other woes this further grief for children lost, 1115 a grief surpassing all? 1116 Kind friends, long have I waited expectantly to know how things would at the palace chance. And lo! I see one of Jason’s servants coming hither, whose hurried gasps for breath 1120 proclaim him the bearer of some fresh tidings. 1121 Fly, fly, Medea! who hast wrought an awful deed, transgressing every law; nor leave behind or sea-borne bark or car that scours the plain. 1124 Why, what hath chanced that calls for such a flight of mine? 1125 The princess is dead, a moment gone, and Creon too, her sire, slain by those drugs of thine. 1127 Tidings most fair are thine! Henceforth shalt thou be ranked amongst my friends and benefactors. 1129 Ha! What? Art sane? Art not distraught, lady, 1130 who hearest with joy the outrage to our royal house done, and art not at the horrid tale afraid? 1132 Somewhat have I, too, to say in answer to thy words. Be not so hasty, friend, but tell the manner of their death, for thou wouldst give me double joy, 1135 if so they perished miserably. 1136 When the children twain whom thou didst bear came with their father and entered the palace of the bride, right glad were we thralls who had shared thy griefs, for instantly from ear to ear a rumour spread 1140 that thou and thy lord had made up your former quarrel. One kissed thy children’s hands, another their golden hair, while I for very joy went with them in person to the women’s chambers. Our mistress, whom now we do revere in thy room, 1145 cast a longing glance at Jason, ere she saw thy children twain; but then she veiled her eyes and turned her blanching cheek away, disgusted at their coming; but thy husband 1150 tried to check his young bride’s angry humour with these words: O, be not angered ’gainst thy friends; cease from wrath and turn once more thy face this way, counting as friends

whomso thy husband counts, and accept these gifts, and for my sake crave thy sire 1155 to remit these children’s exile. Soon as she saw the ornaments, no longer she held out, but yielded to her lord in all; and ere the father and his sons were far from the palace gone, she took the broidered robe and put it on, 1160 and set the golden crown about her tresses, arranging her hair at her bright mirror, with many a happy smile at her breathless counterfeit. Then rising from her seat she passed across the chamber, tripping lightly on her fair white foot, 1165 exulting in the gift, with many a glance at her uplifted ankle. When lo! a scene of awful horror did ensue. In a moment she turned pale, reeled backwards, trembling in every limb, 1170 and sinks upon a seat scarce soon enough to save herself from falling to the ground. An aged dame, one of her company, thinking belike it was a fit from Pan or some god sent, raised a cry of prayer, till from her mouth she saw the foam-flakes issue, her eyeballs 1175 rolling in their sockets, and all the blood her face desert; then did she raise a loud scream far different fiom her former cry. Forthwith one handmaid rushed to her father’s house, another to her new bridegroom to tell his bride’s sad fate, 1180 and the whole house echoed with their running to and fro. 1181 By this time would a quick walker have made the turn in a course of six plethra and reached the goal, when she with one awful shriek awoke, poor sufferer, from her speechless trance and oped her closed eyes, 1185 for against her a twofold anguish was warring. The chaplet of gold about her head was sending forth a wondrous stream of ravening flame, while the fine raiment, thy children’s gift, was preying on the hapless maiden’s fair white flesh; 1190 and she starts from her seat in a blaze and seeks to fly, shaking her hair and head this way and that, to cast the crown therefrom; but the gold held firm to its fastenings, and the flame, as she shook her locks, blazed forth the more with double fury. 1195 Then to the earth she sinks, by the cruel blow o’ercome, past all recognition now save to a father’s eye; for her eyes had lost their tranquil gaze, her face no more its natural look preserved, and from the crown of her head blood and fire in mingled stream ran down; 1200 and from her bones the flesh kept peeling off beneath the gnawing of those secret drugs, e’en as when the pine-tree weeps its tears of pitch, a fearsome sight to see. And all were afraid to touch the corpse, for we were warned by what had chanced. Anon came her hapless father 1205 unto the house, all unwitting of her doom, and stumbles o’er the dead, and loud he cried, and folding his arms about her kissed her, with words like these the while, O my poor, poor child, which of the gods hath destroyed thee thus foully? Who is robbing me of thee, old as I am and 1210 ripe for death? O my child, alas! would I could die with thee! He ceased his sad lament, and would have raised his aged frame, but found himself held fast by the finespun robe as ivy that clings to the branches of the bay, and then ensued a fearful struggle. 1215 He strove to rise, but she still held him back; and if ever he pulled with all his might, from off his bones his aged flesh he tore. At last he gave it up, and breathed forth his soul in awful suffering; for he could no longer master the pain. 1220 So there they lie, daughter and aged sire, dead side by side, a grievous sight that calls for tears. And as for thee, I leave thee out of my consideration, for thyself must discover a means to escape punishment. Not now for the first time I think this human life a shadow; 1225 yea, and without shrinking I will say that they amongst men who pretend to wisdom and expend deep thought on words do incur a serious charge of folly; for amongst mortals no man is happy; wealth may pour in and make 1230 one luckier than another, but none can happy be. 1231 This day the deity, it seems, will mass on Jason, as he well deserves, a heavy load of evils. Woe is thee, daughter of Creon! We pity thy sad fate, gone as thou art to Hades’ halls 1235 as the price of thy marriage with Jason. 1236 My friends, I am resolved upon the deed; at once will I slay my children and then leave this land, without delaying long enough to hand them over to some more savage hand to butcher. 1240 Needs must they die in any case; and since they must, I will slay them—I, the mother that bare them. O heart of mine, steel thyself! Why do I hesitate to do the awful deed that must be done? Come, take the sword, thou wretched

hand of mine! 1245 Take it, and advance to the post whence starts thy life of sorrow! Away with cowardice! Give not one thought to thy babes, how dear they are or how thou art their mother This one brief day forget thy children dear, and after that lament; for though thou wilt slay them yet 1250 they were thy darlings still, and am a lady of sorrows.

1.1.1110

δαίμων οὕτως, φροῦδος ἐς Ἅιδην
θάνατος προφέρων σώματα τέκνων.
πῶς οὖν λύει πρὸς τοῖς ἄλλοις
τήνδ’ ἔτι λύπην ἀνιαροτάτην
παίδων ἕνεκεν
θνητοῖσι θεοὺς ἐπιβάλλειν;
φίλαι, πάλαι τοι προσμένουσα τὴν τύχην
καραδοκῶ τἀκεῖθεν οἶ προβήσεται.
καὶ δὴ δέδορκα τόνδε τῶν Ἰάσονος
στείχοντ’ ὀπαδῶν· πνεῦμα δ’ ἠρεθισμένον
δείκνυσιν ὥς τι καινὸν ἀγγελεῖ κακόν.
ὦ δεινὸν ἔργον παρανόμως εἰργασμένη,
Μήδεια, φεῦγε φεῦγε, μήτε ναΐαν
λιποῦσ’ ἀπήνην μήτ’ ὄχον πεδοστιβῆ.
τί δ’ ἄξιόν μοι τῆσδε τυγχάνει φυγῆς;
ὄλωλεν ἡ τύραννος ἀρτίως κόρη
Κρέων θ’ ὁ φύσας φαρμάκων τῶν σῶν ὕπο.
κάλλιστον εἶπας μῦθον, ἐν δ’ εὐεργέταις
τὸ λοιπὸν ἤδη καὶ φίλοις ἐμοῖς ἔσῃ.
τί φῄς; φρονεῖς μὲν ὀρθὰ κοὐ μαίνῃ, γύναι,
ἥτις, τυράννων ἑστίαν ᾐκισμένη,
χαίρεις κλύουσα κοὐ φοβῇ τὰ τοιάδε;
ἔχω τι κἀγὼ τοῖς γε σοῖς ἐναντίον
λόγοισιν εἰπεῖν· ἀλλὰ μὴ σπέρχου, φίλος,
λέξον δέ· πῶς ὤλοντο; δὶς τόσον γὰρ ἂν
τέρψειας ἡμᾶς, εἰ τεθνᾶσι παγκάκως.
ἐπεὶ τέκνων σῶν ἦλθε δίπτυχος γονὴ
σὺν πατρί, καὶ παρῆλθε νυμφικοὺς δόμους,
ἥσθημεν οἵπερ σοῖς ἐκάμνομεν κακοῖς
δμῶες· δι’ ὤτων δ’ εὐθὺς ἦν πολὺς λόγος

1.1.1140

σὲ καὶ πόσιν σὸν νεῖκος ἐσπεῖσθαι τὸ πρίν.
κυνεῖ δ’ ὃ μέν τις χεῖρ’, ὃ δὲ ξανθὸν κάρα
παίδων· ἐγὼ δὲ καὐτὸς ἡδονῆς ὕπο
στέγας γυναικῶν σὺν τέκνοις ἄμ’ ἐσπόμην.
δέσποινα δ’ ἣν νῦν ἀντὶ σοῦ θαυμάζομεν,
πρὶν μὲν τέκνων σῶν εἰσιδεῖν ξυνωρίδα,
πρόθυμον εἶχ’ ὀφθαλμὸν εἰς Ἰάσονα·
ἔπειτα μέντοι προὐκαλύψατ’ ὄμματα
λευκήν τ’ ἀπέστρεψ’ ἔμπαλιν παρηίδα,
παίδων μυσαχθεῖσ’ εἰσόδους· πόσις δὲ σὸς
ὀργάς τ’ ἀφῄρει καὶ χόλον νεάνιδος
λέγων τάδ’· Οὐ μὴ δυσμενὴς ἔσῃ φίλοις,

παύσῃ δὲ θυμοῦ καὶ πάλιν στρέψεις κάρα,
φίλους νομίζουσ’ οὕσπερ ἂν πόσις σέθεν,
δέξῃ δὲ δῶρα καὶ παραιτήσῃ πατρὸς
φυγὰς ἀφεῖναι παισὶ τοῖσδ’, ἐμὴν χάριν;
ἢ δ’ ὡς ἐσεῖδε κόσμον, οὐκ ἠνέσχετο,
ἀλλ’ ἦνεσ’ ἀνδρὶ πάντα, καὶ πρὶν ἐκ δόμων
μακρὰν ἀπεῖναι πατέρα καὶ παῖδας,
λαβοῦσα πέπλους ποικίλους ἠμπέσχετο,
χρυσοῦν τε θεῖσα στέφανον ἀμφὶ βοστρύχοις
λαμπρῷ κατόπτρῳ σχηματίζεται κόμην,
ἄψυχον εἰκὼ προσγελῶσα σώματος.
κἄπειτ’ ἀναστᾶσ’ ἐκ θρόνων διέρχεται
στέγας, ἁβρὸν βαίνουσα παλλεύκῳ ποδί,
δώροις ὑπερχαίρουσα, πολλὰ πολλάκις
τένοντ’ ἐς ὀρθὸν ὄμμασι σκοπουμένη.
τοὐνθένδε μέντοι δεινὸν ἦν θέαμ’ ἰδεῖν·
χροιὰν γὰρ ἀλλάξασα λεχρία πάλιν
χωρεῖ τρέμουσα κῶλα καὶ μόλις φθάνει

1.1.1170

θρόνοισιν ἐμπεσοῦσα μὴ χαμαὶ πεσεῖν.
καί τις γεραιὰ προσπόλων, δόξασά που
ἢ Πανὸς ὀργὰς ἢ τινὸς θεῶν μολεῖν,
ἀνωλόλυξε, πρίν γ’ ὁρᾷ διὰ στόμα
χωροῦντα λευκὸν ἀφρόν, ὀμμάτων τ’ ἄπο
κόρας στρέφουσαν, αἷμά τ’ οὐκ ἐνὸν χροΐ·
εἶτ’ ἀντίμολπον ἦκεν ὀλολυγῆς μέγαν
κωκυτόν. εὐθὺς δ’ ἢ μὲν ἐς πατρὸς δόμους
ὥρμησεν, ἢ δὲ πρὸς τὸν ἀρτίως πόσιν
φράσουσα νύμφης συμφοράν· ἅπασα δὲ
στέγη πυκνοῖσιν ἐκτύπει δρομήμασιν.
ἤδη δ’ ἀνέλκων κῶλον ἔκπλεθρον δρόμου
ταχὺς βαδιστὴς τερμόνων ἂν ἥπτετο,
ἢ δ’ ἐξ ἀναύδου καὶ μύσαντος ὄμματος
δεινὸν στενάξασ’ ἡ τάλαιν’ ἠγείρετο.
διπλοῦν γὰρ αὐτῇ πῆμ’ ἐπεστρατεύετο·
χρυσοῦς μὲν ἀμφὶ κρατὶ κείμενος πλόκος
θαυμαστὸν ἵει νᾶμα παμφάγου πυρός,
πέπλοι δὲ λεπτοί, σῶν τέκνων δωρήματα,
λεπτὴν ἔδαπτον σάρκα τῆς δυσδαίμονος.
φεύγει δ’ ἀναστᾶσ’ ἐκ θρόνων πυρουμένη,
σείουσα χαίτην κρᾶτά τ’ ἄλλοτ’ ἄλλοσε,
ῥῖψαι θέλουσα στέφανον· ἀλλ’ ἀραρότως
σύνδεσμα χρυσὸς εἶχε, πῦρ δ’, ἐπεὶ κόμην
ἔσεισε, μᾶλλον δὶς τόσως ἐλάμπετο.
πίτνει δ’ ἐς οὖδας συμφορᾷ νικωμένη,
πλὴν τῷ τεκόντι κάρτα δυσμαθὴς ἰδεῖν·
οὔτ’ ὀμμάτων γὰρ δῆλος ἦν κατάστασις
οὔτ’ εὐφυὲς πρόσωπον, αἷμα δ’ ἐξ ἄκρου
ἔσταζε κρατὸς συμπεφυρμένον πυρί,

1.1.1200

σάρκες δ’ ἀπ’ ὀστέων ὥστε πεύκινον δάκρυ
γναθμοῖς ἀδήλοις φαρμάκων ἀπέρρεον,
δεινὸν θέαμα· πᾶσι δ’ ἦν φόβος θιγεῖν
νεκροῦ· τύχην γὰρ εἴχομεν διδάσκαλον.
πατὴρ δ’ ὁ τλήμων συμφορᾶς ἀγνωσίᾳ
ἄφνω προσελθὼν δῶμα προσπίτνει νεκρῷ·
ὤμωξε δ’ εὐθύς, καὶ περιπτύξας χέρας
κυνεῖ προσαυδῶν τοιάδ’· Ὦ δύστηνε παῖ,
τίς σ’ ὧδ’ ἀτίμως δαιμόνων ἀπώλεσε;
τίς τὸν γέροντα τύμβον ὀρφανὸν σέθεν
τίθησιν; οἴμοι, συνθάνοιμί σοι, τέκνον.
ἐπεὶ δὲ θρήνων καὶ γόων ἐπαύσατο,
χρῄζων γεραιὸν ἐξαναστῆσαι δέμας
προσείχεθ’ ὥστε κισσὸς ἔρνεσιν δάφνης
λεπτοῖσι πέπλοις, δεινὰ δ’ ἦν παλαίσματα·
ὃ μὲν γὰρ ἤθελ’ ἐξαναστῆσαι γόνυ,
ἢ δ’ ἀντελάζυτ’. εἰ δὲ πρὸς βίαν ἄγοι,
σάρκας γεραιὰς ἐσπάρασσ’ ἀπ’ ὀστέων.
χρόνῳ δ’ ἀπέσβη καὶ μεθῆχ’ ὁ δύσμορος
ψυχήν· κακοῦ γὰρ οὐκέτ’ ἦν ὑπέρτερος.
κεῖνται δὲ νεκροὶ παῖς τε καὶ γέρων πατὴρ
πέλας, ποθεινὴ δακρύοισι συμφορά.
καί μοι τὸ μὲν σὸν ἐκποδὼν ἔστω λόγου·
γνώσῃ γὰρ αὐτὴ ζημίας ἀποστροφήν.
τὰ θνητὰ δ’ οὐ νῦν πρῶτον ἡγοῦμαι σκιάν,
οὐδ’ ἂν τρέσας εἴποιμι τοὺς σοφοὺς βροτῶν
δοκοῦντας εἶναι καὶ μεριμνητὰς λόγων
τούτους μεγίστην ζημίαν ὀφλισκάνειν.
θνητῶν γὰρ οὐδείς ἐστιν εὐδαίμων ἀνήρ·
ὄλβου δ’ ἐπιρρυέντος εὐτυχέστερος

1.1.1230

ἄλλου γένοιτ’ ἂν ἄλλος, εὐδαίμων δ’ ἂν οὔ.
ἔοιχ’ ὁ δαίμων πολλὰ τῇδ’ ἐν ἡμέρᾳ
κακὰ ξυνάπτειν ἐνδίκως Ἰάσονι.
ὦ τλῆμον, ὡς σου συμφορὰς οἰκτίρομεν,
κόρη Κρέοντος, ἥτις εἰς Ἅιδου δόμους
οἴχῃ γάμων ἕκατι τῶν Ἰάσονος.
φίλαι, δέδοκται τοὔργον ὡς τάχιστά μοι
παῖδας κτανούσῃ τῆσδ’ ἀφορμᾶσθαι χθονός,
καὶ μὴ σχολὴν ἄγουσαν ἐκδοῦναι τέκνα
ἄλλῃ φονεῦσαι δυσμενεστέρᾳ χερί.
πάντως σφ’ ἀνάγκη κατθανεῖν· ἐπεὶ δὲ χρή,
ἡμεῖς κτενοῦμεν, οἵπερ ἐξεφύσαμεν.
ἀλλ’ εἶ’ ὁπλίζου, καρδία. τί μέλλομεν
τὰ δεινὰ κἀναγκαῖα μὴ πράσσειν κακά;
ἄγ’, ὦ τάλαινα χεὶρ ἐμή, λαβὲ ξίφος,
λάβ’, ἕρπε πρὸς βαλβῖδα λυπηρὰν βίου,
καὶ μὴ κακισθῇς μηδ’ ἀναμνησθῇς τέκνων,
ὡς φίλταθ’, ὡς ἔτικτες· ἀλλὰ τήνδε γε

λαθοῦ βραχεῖαν ἡμέραν παίδων σέθεν,
κἄπειτα θρήνει· καὶ γὰρ εἰ κτενεῖς σφ’, ὅμως
φίλοι γ’ ἔφυσαν—δυστυχὴς δ’ ἐγὼ γυνή.

1.1

ἰὼ Γᾶ τε καὶ παμφαὴς
ἀκτὶς Ἀελίου, κατίδετ’ ἴδετε τὰν
ὀλομέναν γυναῖκα, πρὶν φοινίαν
τέκνοις προσβαλεῖν χέρ’ αὐτοκτόνον·
τεᾶς γὰρ ἀπὸ χρυσέας γονᾶς
ἔβλαστεν, θεοῦ δ’ αἷμά τι πίτνειν
φόβος ὑπ’ ἀνέρων.
ἀλλά νιν, ὦ φάος διογενές, κάτειρ-
γε κατάπαυσον, ἔξελ’ οἴκων φονίαν
τάλαιναν τ’ Ἐρινὺν ὑπ’ ἀλαστόρων.

1.1

μάταν μόχθος ἔρρει τέκνων,
ἆρα μάταν γένος φίλιον ἔτεκες, ὦ
κυανεᾶν λιποῦσα Συμπληγάδων
πετρᾶν ἀξενωτάταν ἐσβολάν;
δειλαία, τί σοι φρενῶν βαρὺς
χόλος προσπίτνει καὶ δυσμενὴς
φόνος; ἀμείβεται
χαλεπὰ γὰρ βροτοῖς ὁμογενῆ μιά-
σματα ἐπὶ γαῖαν αὐτοφόνταις ξυνῳ-
δὰ θεόθεν πίτνοντ’ ἐπὶ δόμοις ἄχη.

1.3

αἰαῖ.

1.2

—ἀκούεις βοὰν ἀκούεις τέκνων;
—ἰὼ τλᾶμον, ὦ κακοτυχὲς γύναι.
—οἴμοι, τί δράσω; ποῖ φύγω μητρὸς χέρας;
—οὐκ οἶδ’, ἄδελφε φίλτατ’· ὀλλύμεσθα γάρ.
παρέλθω δόμους; ἀρῆξαι φόνον
δοκεῖ μοι τέκνοις.
—ναί, πρὸς θεῶν, ἀρήξατ’· ἐν δέοντι γάρ.
—ὡς ἐγγὺς ἤδη γ’ ἐσμὲν ἀρκύων ξίφους.
—τάλαιν’, ὡς ἄρ’ ἦσθα πέτρος ἢ σίδα-
ρος, ἅτις τέκνων
ὃν ἔτεκες ἄροτον αὐτόχειρι μοίρᾳ κτενεῖς.

1.2

—μίαν δὴ κλύω μίαν τῶν πάρος
γυναῖκ’ ἐν φίλοις χέρα βαλεῖν τέκνοις·
Ἰνὼ μανεῖσαν ἐκ θεῶν, ὅθ’ ἡ Διὸς
δάμαρ νιν ἐξέπεμψε δωμάτων ἄλῃ·

1286 πίτνει δ’ ἀ τάλαιν’ ἐς ἅλμαν φόνῳ
1287 τέκνων δυσσεβεῖ,
1288 ἀκτῆς ὑπερτείνασα ποντίας πόδα,
1289 δυοῖν τε παίδοιν συνθανοῦσ’ ἀπόλλυται.
1290 τί δῆτ’ οὖν γένοιτ’ ἂν ἔτι δεινόν; ὦ
1291 γυναικῶν λέχος
1292 πολύπονον, ὅσα βροτοῖς ἔρεξας ἤδη κακά.

1.1

1389 ἀλλά σ’ Ἐρινὺς ὀλέσειε τέκνων
1390 φονία τε Δίκη.
1391 τίς δὲ κλύει σοῦ θεὸς ἢ δαίμων,
1392 τοῦ ψευδόρκου καὶ ξειναπάτου;
1393 φεῦ φεῦ, μυσαρὰ καὶ παιδολέτορ.
1394 στεῖχε πρὸς οἴκους καὶ θάπτ’ ἄλοχον.
1395 στείχω, δισσῶν γ’ ἄμορος τέκνων.
1396 οὔπω θρηνεῖς· μένε καὶ γῆρας.
1397 ὦ τέκνα φίλτατα.
1397b μητρί γε, σοὶ δ’ οὔ.
1398 κἄπειτ’ ἔκανες;
1398b σέ γε πημαίνουσ’.
1399 ὤμοι, φιλίου χρῄζω στόματος
1400 παίδων ὁ τάλας προσπτύξασθαι.
1401 νῦν σφε προσαυδᾷς, νῦν ἀσπάζῃ,
1402 τότ’ ἀπωσάμενος.
1402b δός μοι πρὸς θεῶν
1403 μαλακοῦ χρωτὸς ψαῦσαι τέκνων.
1404 οὐκ ἔστι· μάτην ἔπος ἔρριπται.
1405 Ζεῦ, τάδ’ ἀκούεις ὡς ἀπελαυνόμεθ’,
1406 οἷά τε πάσχομεν ἐκ τῆς μυσαρᾶς
1407 καὶ παιδοφόνου τῆσδε λεαίνης;
1408 ἀλλ’ ὁπόσον γοῦν πάρα καὶ δύναμαι
1409 τάδε καὶ θρηνῶ κἀπιθεάζω,
1410 μαρτυρόμενος δαίμονας ὥς μοι
1411 τέκνα κτείνασ’ ἀποκωλύεις
1412 ψαῦσαί τε χεροῖν θάψαι τε νεκρούς,
1413 οὓς μήποτ’ ἐγὼ φύσας ὄφελον
1414 πρὸς σοῦ φθιμένους ἐπιδέσθαι.
1415 πολλῶν ταμίας Ζεὺς ἐν Ὀλύμπῳ,
1416 πολλὰ δ’ ἀέλπτως κραίνουσι θεοί·
1417 καὶ τὰ δοκηθέντ’ οὐκ ἐτελέσθη,
1418 τῶν δ’ ἀδοκήτων πόρον ηὗρε θεός.
1419 τοιόνδ’ ἀπέβη τόδε πρᾶγμα.